Welcome Back!

A lot has happened since this prospect guide originally dropped in March. Davante Adams and Tyreek Hill were both traded. Deshaun Watson became a Cleveland Brown. Will Smith slapped Chris Rock on stage at the Oscars.

Just some normal things in the year 2022.

The NFL Draft went down, too. And now that the draft is over, we've got a whole lot more to analyze on the fantasy football front.

As promised, this guide got a little makeover post-draft. Portions of it remained the same — the Year 2 Model section is unchanged, as is the breakdown of what goes into the Z-Prospect Model — but there are important modifications to note:

- All draft profiles now include an updated Z-Prospect Model score along with their listed Draft Capital Delta.
- Relevant, higher-end rookies have an updated profile breakdown that talks about the player's new outlook. On a player's profile page, you'll see the word "update" before their blurb, designating new information about the player.
- The rookie rankings cheatsheet is redone.
- A new Z-Prospect Model cheatsheet was created to provide a snapshot of how the model views each player. This cheatsheet also includes a historical hit rate chart by percentile grouping.
- V3 Update: Very slight shift in rankings alongside a fix in Velus Jones' prospect profile.

Let's crush some rookie drafts.

LATE•ROUND PROSPECT GUIDE

JJ Zachariason | 2022 Edition

Contents

About the Author

I don't pretend to be a professional draft scout. I'm just a 30-something-year-old dad living in suburban Charlotte, North Carolina who's got access to college football data.

I've also got an obsession with fantasy football.

My journey as a fantasy football analyst started in 2012 when my e-book, *The Late-Round Quarterback*, was published. At the time, drafting quarterbacks near the top of your fantasy football drafts was smart. Or, that's what everyone wanted you to believe.

That piece of digital literature got my name out there, and about a year after it published, I got a call from numberFire. I became numberFire's Editor-In-Chief in 2013. Then, the company was bought by FanDuel in 2015. Up until January 2022, I served as FanDuel's Editor-In-Chief.

Throughout this nine-year adventure of making a living through fantasy football, I've won four Fantasy Sports Writers Association awards that no one cares about, and I've gotten a lot of stuff wrong.

Wait, what? Did I say that out loud?

Look. I talk about what I think a bunch of dudes in pads are going to do on a football field. I won't get close to everything right.

Neither will you. Neither will your leaguemates.

You don't need to be perfect to win at fantasy football. You just need to be better than the fools you're playing against.

In order to do that, you need a process. You need some repeatable thing you can do year in and year out that yields strong results.

That's what I'm here for. I'm here to teach you that process.

About This Guide

I built my first NFL prospect model in 2017.

I didn’t know what I was doing.

It seemed like the right thing to do. I was about five years into my professional career as a fantasy football analyst, and I needed a project to take my evaluation game to the next level.

So I built a mathematical prospect model to help my dynasty fantasy football breakdowns. Or, I should say, a “prospect model”.

It sucked.

It didn’t suck because the model failed to produce hits that year. Packers running back Aaron Jones came from that class, and I — along with my trusty “model” — was all about him. Kareem Hunt, too. And even Kenny Golladay.

Seems pretty good, right?

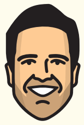
Well, in hindsight, I was pretty fortunate. Because the model was a little aimless.

It was far too convoluted, and it wasn’t solving a super specific problem. Testing was done to ensure historical results made sense, but the process from the start of draft season to the end of it felt…off. It felt incomplete.

After another year manipulating things and crossing my fingers, we hit the 2019 season.

When I say the 2019 draft season was bad for your boy, I mean it was “went to school but forgot to wear pants” levels of bad.

The Nickname “Babytron”



While that initial prospect model had its issues, it did get me onto Kenny Golladay early, forcing me to give him the terrible nickname Babytron. Detroit beat writers have never forgiven me.

My model loved Andy Isabella. *Loved* him. It loved a 5-foot-9, 187-pound wide receiver from the powerhouse University of Massachusetts football program.

For real.

I've got nothing against any Minutemen out there. We're just not exactly talking about LSU here.

I also went against the math during that 2019 season when building my dynasty rookie rankings. Mecole Hardman didn't pop whatsoever in that model, but I decided I'd be into him after he was selected to Patrick Mahomes' Chiefs.

Like Bruno, I don't want to talk about it.

After that draft analysis failure, I knew something had to change.

So I worked. I researched. I tested.

And I built running back and wide receiver models that are now better, easier to understand, and relatively simple.

Scouting is difficult. NFL teams pump millions of dollars into their draft process each winter, only to select a second-rounder who contributes absolutely nothing for their football team. Teams let players like Stefon Diggs fall to the fifth round. They take Clyde Edwards-Helaire over Jonathan Taylor.

Let's not pretend anyone has this completely figured out.

That's sort of why scouting through numbers is so intriguing.

Traditionally — especially outside of the fantasy football world — we've seen film grinders tell us who's good based on what their eyes are showing them. There's nothing wrong with that, but ask yourself: are the results *that* spectacular?

Like I've said, I'm no professional scout. I watch film to make sure I don't sound like an idiot on podcasts, but taking pages and pages of notes while watching a game in slow motion isn't my thing.

My thing is numbers. And it's communicating ideas that have to do with numbers.

That's what this prospect guide is all about. I'm not just going to hand you a spreadsheet that shows some arbitrary prospect score for a player and say, "OK, have at it!"

I'm going to explain what goes into that score, and I'm going to give you the tools to utilize the models to their fullest potential.

We're going to get deep into this stuff.

We're going to get nerdy.

We're also going to win.

The Z-Prospect Model

Overview

Fantasy football is a numbers-driven game. It's a game about numbers. We care about production. So if we can nail down the most important inputs to that production, we'll be long-term winners.

Predicting what's going to happen on a football field isn't easy. No one should be telling you otherwise. Your goal, though, isn't to be flawless. It's to be better than your competition.

And, chances are, your competition probably doesn't have a sound process that they follow year in and year out for most things fantasy football. With a dynasty rookie draft, they're probably listening to people they trust, doing a little research themselves, and subjectively picking one guy over the next.

When we scout through numbers, we're able to formulate a trustworthy backbone. We can create a winning process that's repeatable.

After the Rookie Rankings Failure of 2019™, I approached my model building with more purpose. What was the very specific thing I wanted to solve?

After some thought, my brain put this out into the universe:

> The goal of the prospect models is to predict how well a running back and wide receiver will perform in fantasy football across his first three seasons in the league.

Was it random?

...Kind of?

The thought process behind the model's mission was that you're going to have a general idea of how good a player is after his first three years as a pro. While later breakouts happen in the NFL, they're rarer than a good tweet from my Twitter account.

The next question, then, was, "How?" As in, "How do you measure performance for a player across his first three seasons?"

You could look at raw fantasy points scored, but that wouldn't properly account for inevitable injuries. You could look at a player's best points per game average, but sometimes fluky seasons happen, too.

To meet in the middle, I decided to average out a player's best two seasons in points per game (in point per reception leagues) across the first three years of his career. That could've come in Year 2 and Year 3, or it could've happened in Year 1 and Year 2. Whatever top-two seasons were best in points per game, those seasons were averaged out and used for that historical player.

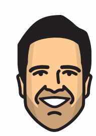
Moving forward, I'll be referring to this as a player's "B2S" score, standing for "best two seasons."

The very next thing I thought about was draft capital, or where a player was selected in the NFL Draft. If there was perfect correlation between draft capital and a player's B2S, then why build a model in the first place? You could just look at the NFL Draft and select players in your rookie draft based on that alone.

So, I tested it.

I took a giant sample of every wide receiver and running back who was either drafted or who attended the NFL Combine since 2006, and I threw them into a database. I then associated each player with their draft selection, where undrafted players got assigned the same number.

Sample Sizes and Testing



When you see fantasy analysts talk about things like "correlation" and "R squared" on social media, keep in mind that those numbers are fully dependent on the sample being analyzed.

After seeing the correlation between draft capital and the B2S averages among hundreds and hundreds of players, I knew what needed to happen next.

> **I needed to beat that correlation by a significant margin to make these models worthwhile.**

To reiterate what I just said, if what I was building wouldn't be any more predictive than draft capital itself, what was the point?

My previous, iffier models utilized college production, some NFL Combine metrics, and player age to help determine who was good and who wasn't. Fundamentally, I knew that scouting through numbers was possible, and I knew a lot of the metrics I had previously utilized mattered to some degree.

> **As I tend to say, only a fraction of productive college players are super productive in the NFL, but most super productive NFL players were productive in college.**

There had to be data trends to lean on.

Without boring you to death, I ended up testing a ton of different metrics to see if I could beat draft capital. I got very close to my goal before having the realization that draft capital itself is an important piece to the puzzle here, too.

I mean, think about it: Where a player gets drafted has so much intrinsic value. A group of smart people decided to choose that player. They said, "He's really good, we've got to get him in the first round!"

That's free evaluation for us.

Not only that, but where a player gets drafted can influence how quickly that player is able to find the field. When a coach or team invests strong draft capital in someone, chances are, they're going to really want that player to succeed.

So I plugged it into my model.

Voila!

With the help of draft capital, both the wide receiver and running back models predicted a player's best two seasons across his first three years way better than draft capital alone.

Oh, there's more.

Technically, we're not getting full utilization out of a model like this if it's simply beating out draft capital. In fantasy football, we're trying to crush our friends. Our coworkers. Strangers from hundreds of miles away who share the obsession.

We're not trying to be better than NFL teams.

So instead of seeing if the model was better at predicting a player's B2S than draft capital, I looked to see if it was more predictive than rookie draft average draft position (ADP), or where fantasy managers were selecting these players in drafts.

What I'm attempting to solve is different than what an NFL team is trying to solve. What I'm attempting to solve is *exactly* what other fantasy football managers are trying to solve.

Using My Fantasy League's historical ADP, the results were clear: the model I had built performed better than the public. Significantly better.

Phew.

The Z-Prospect Model (because my last name starts with the letter Z, and I'm really creative) was born.

The Inputs

You're probably wondering what goes into this thing, huh?

Fortunately, it's not super complicated.

Let's start with the running back model first.

The running back model produces a size score, which is essentially based on a player's Body Mass Index, or BMI. Are smaller running backs worse at football than larger running backs? Not necessarily. Do coaches give bigger-bodied backs more work in the NFL? Yes. Since volume drives fantasy football, that's likely the reason BMI matters to this model.

The model also utilizes what's called a Speed Score, which is just a weight-adjusted 40-yard dash time. Bill Barnwell thought of the metric years ago after recognizing that not all 40-yard dashers are alike. It's more impressive when a 240-pound running back runs a 4.4 40 versus a 190-pound one.

And the model agrees! Mostly. A Speed Score threshold of 90 needs to be hit — a modest number for any aspiring back — or else points are deducted from a running back's prospect score. But if a running back hits, say, a 99th percentile Speed Score, it gets recognized the same way a 65th percentile Speed Score would.

Next, there's age. Quite simply, older running backs entering the league get dinged a little more than someone who's just 20 or 21 years old.

Finally, there are three main production metrics that the model utilizes to formulate a stat score: best-season reception share, best-season total touchdown share, and best-season total yards per team play. Each metric has a different weight and degree of usability within the model.

Even though they're running backs, there's a lot of signal that comes from best-season reception share, which measures the percentage of team receptions a specific running back accumulates.

Talent in Fantasy Football

Running back size is a good example of where we sometimes have to separate talent from what matters in fantasy football. Smaller running backs can be very effective for NFL teams, but those teams rarely feed those backs.

My hypothesis for this is that receptions show versatility.

A lot of running backs with high reception shares don't actually go on to be top-notch pass-catchers in the NFL. Having a good reception share in college, though, tells us that these players were used in a lot of different ways, and that's evidence for talent.

Total touchdown share is pretty self-explanatory, but it's the total number of touchdowns a running back has divided by his team's offensive touchdown tally. Of the three metrics, it's the least important, likely because touchdowns can be a little random.

And then there's total yards per team play, which is a way of showing how effective a player was within his own offense. What's cool about the metric is that it doesn't care about specifically volume or specifically efficiency. If a back averaged just four yards per carry but saw a ton of work, he's still got a shot to do well within the metric. If a player is more of a pass-catching specialist and was really efficient with his touches, he can still be fine in yards per team play, too.

Size, Speed Score, age, and those three production metrics. That's it. Add in draft capital, and we're cookin'.

The wide receiver model has a little more to it.

Age is in the running back model, but it matters a lot more at wide receiver.

There's a metric called Breakout Age, or the age when a college wide receiver hits a Dominator Rating of 20% or greater. What's Dominator Rating? Simply put, it's a number that measures a player's market share in his offense.

Breakout Age, then, is the age when a wide receiver sees a large share of his college offense.

The correlation between Breakout Age and NFL performance exists

Breakout Age Calculations

You've likely seen fantasy analysts talk about Breakout Age before, but did you know that there's not one singular way to calculate it? I use a threshold that works for my model, but there's merit to other Breakout Age calculations.

because when a human being does something well at a young age, that human being is probably talented at doing that thing.

If a Freshman wide receiver is regularly beating upperclassman cornerbacks, it's impressive. That wide receiver hasn't had the same type of practice and experience, but he's still able to post great numbers.

Along the same lines of Breakout Age is whether or not a player declared early for the draft.

> **When a wide receiver leaves college for the NFL as a non-Senior, that's a sign that he's good at football. If he wasn't, he likely would've stayed in school.**

Since 2011, we've seen 43 wide receivers get selected in the first round of the NFL Draft. Of that group, 32 have played at least three seasons in the NFL — we're not counting players who were recently drafted.

Among those 32, 9 were non-early declares, playing a full four years in college.

Let's judge these players the same way the model does: by looking at a player's best two seasons average in points per game across his first three years. Or, as I called it earlier, B2S.

When we do that, the nine wide receivers who didn't declare early see an average of 8.4 PPR points per game. Their best two seasons in points per game over their first three in the league averaged out to 8.4.

The remaining 23 wide receivers — the early-declare group — saw an average of 12.6.

The list of nine players is borderline abysmal, too: Kendall Wright, Michael Floyd, DeVante Parker, Tavon Austin, Corey Davis, Josh

Early-Declare First-Rounders

Over the last couple of years, we've had some players who could buck the recent negative trend of first-round wide receivers busting who weren't early declares. The most obvious ones are Devonta Smith and Brandon Aiyuk.

Doctson, Kevin White, Phillip Dorsett, and AJ Jenkins.

If a wide receiver didn't declare early, he's not completely done for. Just remember that we're playing probability here. Historical numbers tell us that early-declare wide receivers are better than the alternative.

Now, unlike the running back model, NFL Combine athleticism measurables don't matter for wide receivers. And while size is an input, it's not hugely important. At least compared to running backs.

That may sound crazy. Shouldn't a bigger-bodied, physically-gifted wide receiver be highly sought after?

Not necessarily.

Subjectively, you probably would want an enormous and athletic wide receiver on your team over a tiny and slow one.

> But it's very rare for completely unathletic wide receivers to get drafted early in the first place.

Part of the reason size and athleticism isn't a big deal in the wide receiver model is because it's likely already captured in draft capital, and draft capital is in the wide receiver model.

Not only that, but wide receivers do different jobs on a football field. Cooper Kupp doesn't win the same way DK Metcalf does. Keenan Allen doesn't do the same things Mike Evans does. Metcalf and Evans are more physically dominant, and even though they're highly productive as pros, Kupp and Allen are, too.

If a player completely bombs the NFL Combine — and I'm talking like, 15th percentile marks across the board — you'd probably want to remove that player from your consideration set. Chances are, though, that same player won't have good draft capital, and he likely wouldn't have had the best college production profile. So, in the end, the lack of athleticism and size doesn't matter much because more important factors weren't going his way.

This is why it was difficult to knock Devonta Smith's size when he was entering the league in 2021. Was his low BMI a concern? Slightly, I suppose. But Smith had an absurd production profile while being selected 10th overall. To me, the biggest knock was the fact that he wasn't an early-declare wide receiver, not the fact that he's a skinny dude.

If he ends up completely failing in the NFL, we can't say it was because of his size.

Moving on, there are three production statistics the wide receiver model focuses on for a player's stat score: best-season receptions per game, best-season receiving yards per team pass attempt, and best-season touchdown share.

Z-Prospect Model Stat Scores

You may see references to "stat score" throughout the guide, and all it means is a player's score when looking solely at production metrics.

On its own, receptions per game isn't that great of a metric. It doesn't even factor in team offense or tendencies — it's not a market share-related statistic.

My guess as to why it helps the wide receiver model is because it's working alongside best-season receiving yards per team pass attempt.

Receiving yards per team pass attempt is similar to total yards per team play at running back in that it's a market share statistic that kind of looks like an efficiency one. Big plays can admittedly skew the results of the metric — albeit slightly — so my guess is that adding in receptions per game provides a baseline for volume.

To put that in a more consumable way, if a player is actually distorting his receiving yards per team play number through big plays, receptions per game can help bring things back to Earth. Because it's going to be hard to create monster plays reception after reception. And if the wideout *is* doing that reception after reception, then he's probably a good wide receiver.

Receiving yards per team pass attempt is the metric that gets the most weight in the model. The one that gets the least amount of love is touchdown share, which, just like the running back model, is probably because touchdowns bring some variance.

So we've got Breakout Age, early-declare status, size, draft capital, and three production metrics. The final two things that go into the wide receiver model are what I call "conference factor" and "teammate factor." Wideouts who played in specific conferences get additional points added to their prospect score. That seems to matter more for the position than at running back. And receivers who played with good teammates in college get a slight bump, too.

The Outputs

The nice part about prospecting through data is that you can test and see if a model works.

	Wide Receiver (Best Two-Year Average; Years 1-3)						
Percentile	< 10	10+	12+	14+	16+	18+	20+
95-100	28%	72%	67%	50%	28%	17%	6%
90-95	58%	42%	21%	16%	11%	0%	0%
85-90	42%	58%	42%	26%	16%	5%	0%
80-85	57%	43%	38%	24%	14%	0%	0%
75-80	72%	28%	22%	11%	0%	0%	0%
70-75	90%	10%	5%	5%	0%	0%	0%
65-70	90%	10%	0%	0%	0%	0%	0%
60-65	96%	4%	4%	4%	0%	0%	0%

The table above shows the results of the wide receiver model from 2011 through 2019. The left column gives you the percentile bucket that a prospect fell into within the Z-Prospect Model, and the middle of the table tells you the percentage of players from that percentile to have averaged a particular points per game mark in B2S.

Let's pretend a wide receiver scored 10, 12, and 17 PPR points per game across his first three seasons in the league. We'd throw out that average of 10 (his lowest points per game output) and completely focus on the 12 and 17 in order to capture his B2S. The average of those two numbers is 14.5, placing that wide receiver in the “14+” bucket but not the “16+” one.

Again, that’s what the B2S acronym is all about.

As you can see, the wide receiver model isn’t spotless. In fact, players ranking in the 80th to 90th percentile have fared better than players who ranked in the 90th to 95th! It doesn’t mean the model is wrong or bad — that particular example is most likely due to sample size variance.

> What’s most important with a table like this is the general trends.

There’s a very clear drop-off when a player is unable to hit the 80th percentile as a prospect. And if a wideout is a 95th percentile incoming rookie, his chance of hitting big is pret-tay, pret-tay good.

As you know, the model is attempting to solve a player’s B2S, or the average of a player’s best-two seasons in PPR points per game across his first three years in the NFL. Sometimes looking at things in that way can be a little confusing.

Rather than stare at a chart that depicts a player’s B2S, how about one where it just shows his single best season in PPR points per game?

Wide Receiver (Best Single-Season PPR PPG; Years 1-3)

Percentile	< 10	10+	12+	14+	16+	18+	20+
95-100	17%	83%	67%	61%	39%	39%	17%
90-95	47%	53%	42%	26%	16%	5%	0%
85-90	21%	79%	53%	42%	26%	21%	11%
80-85	52%	48%	38%	29%	24%	5%	0%
75-80	67%	33%	22%	22%	11%	6%	0%
70-75	90%	10%	5%	5%	0%	0%	0%
65-70	85%	15%	0%	0%	0%	0%	0%
60-65	92%	8%	4%	4%	0%	0%	0%

This table should be a little easier to grasp. Essentially, among 95th to 100th percentile wide receivers from 2011 through 2019, 17% failed to have a single double-digit PPR points per game season during their first three years in the league. Meanwhile, nearly 40% of them had a campaign with 18 or more PPR points.

That's a top-five season at the position, for the record.

The running back visuals aren't quite as appetizing as the wide receiver ones.

	Running Back (Best Two-Year Average; Years 1-3)						
Percentile	< 10	10+	12+	14+	16+	18+	20+
95-100	21%	79%	71%	64%	50%	43%	29%
90-95	40%	60%	33%	27%	13%	7%	7%
85-90	38%	62%	38%	8%	8%	8%	8%
80-85	40%	60%	40%	40%	40%	20%	0%
75-80	69%	31%	15%	8%	8%	0%	0%
70-75	81%	19%	6%	6%	6%	6%	0%
65-70	92%	8%	8%	0%	0%	0%	0%
60-65	80%	20%	13%	0%	0%	0%	0%

Why does the running back model look a little worse, you ask? Well, for starters, the model itself isn't as predictive as the wide receiver one. And it could be because — this is merely a hypothesis, but I think it makes sense — fewer running backs are able to see the field in an NFL game.

At the end of the day, a running back's production is the result of a coaching decision. Someone on the sidelines decided that a particular back was worthwhile enough to be on the field. You'd hope that it was because the running back was #GoodAtTheGame, and that's why we should still care about running back talent.

But, in the end, more wide receivers are on the field than running backs on a given play and in a given game. That not only allows wide receiver talent to be shown off, but it also creates a lot more gray area with these numbers.

To think of this another way, if a running back isn't a starter, he's not doing a whole lot. It creates pretty binary results. If a wide receiver is the number-three option in his offense, he's giving you more consistent production than a backup running back who's standing on the sideline.

With a running back, a coach could theoretically take a sixth-round pick and hand him 200 carries per year over his first three seasons in the league. With wide receivers, they need to actually get open in order to see a target and to produce. This is why we should all be believers that targets are largely earned as opposed to given to wide receivers.

Regardless, the running back model's output shares some similarities to the wide receiver one. If a back is unable to hit the 80th percentile in the Z-Prospect Model, then we should be skeptical of that player.

And that same conclusion can be drawn when looking at how running backs have performed in their top season across their first three in the NFL.

Running Back (Best Single-Season PPR PPG; Years 1-3)							
Percentile	< 10	10+	12+	14+	16+	18+	20+
95-100	21%	79%	71%	71%	57%	43%	36%
90-95	33%	67%	67%	33%	33%	13%	7%
85-90	23%	77%	62%	31%	8%	8%	8%
80-85	27%	73%	53%	40%	40%	27%	20%
75-80	62%	38%	31%	23%	8%	8%	0%
70-75	69%	31%	19%	6%	6%	6%	6%
65-70	75%	25%	8%	8%	0%	0%	0%
60-65	60%	40%	13%	13%	0%	0%	0%

These tables are important to keep in mind as you read through this guide. I'll be providing percentile scores for prospects, and you can use those scores to get a rough idea of a player's hit rate.

Draft Capital Delta

I've talked a lot about draft capital and its importance to the models. Naturally, because it's an input, there's a connection between how the model sees players and where they were drafted. Especially at running back, where draft capital matters more.

Not only that, but good players are often beloved in both film evaluation and analytical analysis. Ja'Marr Chase broke the Z-Prospect Model last year, but traditional scouting saw him as an insanely good prospect, too. There's obvious overlap in the way the model may view a player and the way the NFL — draft capital — does.

What about when there's not?

Back in 2020, Darnell Mooney was selected by the Bears with the 173rd overall pick. Among the wideouts in the model's database, that placed Mooney in the 54th percentile for draft capital. Remember, there are a lot of undrafted players in the sample, so 173rd may seem late when it's really not.

Mooney had a Z-Prospect score in the 66th percentile. That means he looked better in the model than how the actual NFL Draft viewed him by 12 points, a margin that's one of the highest among wide receivers in the dataset. In turn, he's someone who would've hypothetically been on my radar coming out of the draft as a later-round rookie pick.

A Dynasty Sleeper?

While Darnell Mooney outpaced draft capital by a nice margin in the Z-Prospect Model, one player who stood out even more was 49ers receiver Jauan Jennings.

When looking through this lens historically, it's pretty interesting. The model has seen 14 wide receivers since 2011 drafted before Pick 100 while outperforming draft capital by at least 5 points. That is, their Z-Prospect percentile was at least five percentage points higher than their draft capital percentile.

Clearly not all of these players were hits, but there were some good ones in there, including Tyler Boyd, Tyler Lockett, Allen Robinson, Jarvis Landry, and Keenan Allen.

Things aren't nearly as pretty on the flip side. Among the 18 wide receivers drafted in the top-100 who underperformed in Z-Prospect score versus draft capital by at least five percentage points — the players who were seemingly overdrafted — the biggest miss was probably Brandon Aiyuk. Maybe Chase Claypool? Sterling Shepard? Those are the only three wide receivers who've even sniffed relevancy, with guys like Chris Conley, Breshad Perriman, Braxton Miller, Dante Pettis, and Anthony Miller joining them on the list.

The same type of trend sort of exists at running back, too. Draft capital gets more weight in the running back model than it does at wide receiver, so our group of players being drastically better or worse than where they were drafted is a little smaller.

If we were to do the exact same thing at running back as we just did with wide receiver, though, and if we focus on *all* running backs who were drafted, guess which running back outperformed draft capital most in Z-Prospect score since 2011?

Aaron Jones.

When looking at all *undrafted* running backs, guess who ranked in the top-five?

James Robinson.

I know, I know — I can pick and choose the favorable outcomes in the model all day long.

The thing is, I've got receipts.

There's a reason I was into Aaron Jones when he came out of school. There's a reason I talked up James Robinson on my podcast before and after his NFL Draft.

It's because they're players who looked strong analytically, but their draft capital — the general market — wasn't there for them.

Utilizing what I call "Draft Capital Delta" can aid you in spotting early-round busts and late-round gems. Like most things prospecting-related, it's far from perfect. There are plenty of misses with the method. But it's undoubtedly a useful tool that I'll reference with prospect profiles.

Adding Subjectivity

These models are cool and all, but I'll be the first to tell you that they won't give you all the answers. There are actually some fundamental flaws to them.

Look no further than Jaylen Waddle. Coming out of Alabama last year, Waddle didn't have a very good production profile. He didn't have a great Breakout Age, and all three production metrics were below average.

Waddle had a Z-Prospect score that placed him in the 96th percentile. Nothing wrong with that. But given he went sixth overall, he had a Draft Capital Delta of -3.0%, telling us that he was overdrafted.

In that 2021 draft class, Ja'Marr Chase, Devonta Smith, Rashod Bateman, and Elijah Moore all had better or similar prospect scores compared to Waddle. My rankings, however, placed Waddle third at wide receiver in a tier above Bateman and Moore.

Why?

Nuance. That's why.

> Seeing how a player looks in a model can be helpful, but I'll never tell you to stop there. Looking at a player's journey and — gasp — *watching* the player play is always a solid idea as well.

With Waddle, there were clear reasons as to why his analytical profile was lacking. During his Freshman year, he outproduced first-round wide receiver talent. His snaps did dip as a Sophomore, but then as a Junior — his final collegiate season — he was injured after his first four games played. Through those four games, he had more receiving yards for Alabama than Heisman winner Devonta Smith.

Should we make small-sample assumptions? No, of course not. We can't say that Waddle would've posted better numbers than Smith had he played the entirety of his Junior season.

We just don't have to think in such a black and white way.

The fact that Waddle still ranked as a 96th percentile prospect in the Z-Prospect Model despite the poor production profile was telling. Imagine a world where he didn't get hurt during his final season! It wasn't hard to give him a subjective boost in rankings as a result.

Considering the Waddle example, you may be wondering why the model doesn't use per-game numbers for some of the metrics.

To be blunt, it's because it doesn't matter.

Looking at yards per team pass attempt in games played, for instance, is good context to have, but you run into issues where a player's top season is all twisted because of a small sample size.

I've tested it, and full-season numbers work better within this model. If more detail is needed, I can always add subjective context.

Another good illustration of where my model and rankings disagreed was with Antonio Gibson a couple of years back.

At the start of the draft process in 2020, people didn't even know if Gibson was going to play wide receiver or running back in the NFL. He had mostly played wideout at Memphis, carrying the ball just 33 times in two seasons there. That resulted in some poor numbers in the model aside from reception share.

But Gibson was a beast. Athleticism matters more at running back, and Gibson had an even better Speed Score than Jonathan Taylor out of that class. Add in the 66th overall draft capital, and it was easy to fall in love with Gibson, even if the model gave him a negative Draft Capital Delta.

It's OK to view players differently than how a model views them.

A Post-Draft Demand

The last line in my post-draft writeup about Antonio Gibson read, "If Washington can find ways to get him the ball, the sky's the limit." So, uh, Washington, can we please get the man more targets?

Let me give you one last example. Many analysts have found success looking at return yardage as an input for wide receiver prospects. If a wideout had a lot of return yards on punts and kicks, then it's probably a sign that the wide receiver has ability — coaches put their best play-makers in those return positions.

My model doesn't utilize return yardage, but when I'm perusing prospects, it's something I keep in the back of my mind as a positive indicator.

There's nothing wrong with doing that. There's nothing wrong with adding a little subjectivity to your evaluation as you use the model as your guide.

Positional Focus

So far, you've learned all about the inner workings of the Z-Prospect Model. You know which metrics are most meaningful to it, you can see the importance of draft capital, and you're aware that it's not perfect.

Before sending you off to read about the 2022 class, your brain may be wondering why I've put such emphasis on running back and wide receiver and not quarterback and tight end.

Great question!

As you know, running backs and wide receivers are the lifeblood of fantasy football. You start more of them — they're higher in demand — so they're the central pieces to the game.

That alone was the reason I went on the journey of building running back and wide receiver models. They just matter more.

But I've also started the creation of quarterback and tight end models, too. It just hasn't worked out.

Yet.

I do plan on getting to a point where my analysis for quarterbacks and tight ends has more of a foundation, but it's harder. Straight up. There are fewer of them, for one, and finding the right things to hone in on has been challenging.

It doesn't mean that I can't analyze those positions or that a tight end or quarterback model will never come. It's just that, at this time, I'd rather give you the goods on the positions that are most relevant.

Next year? We'll have to see.

2022 Prospect Profiles

Overview

It's rare for a running back or wide receiver to emerge as a star in the league without an NFL Combine invite. It certainly happens — Austin Ekeler and Adam Thielen both became studs after being skipped over.

But just because there are exceptions to the rule doesn't mean the rule is invalid.

Strictly from a probability perspective, for fantasy football purposes, we should care most about the players who were invited to the NFL Combine. Period. That shouldn't be debated.

So that's where the focus is at for these prospect profiles.

There were 36 running backs invited to this year's NFL Combine. There were 40 wide receivers who were awarded the same honor.

> I profiled them. Every single one of them. I looked at their analytical profiles, and I studied the type of player they may be at the next level.

These outlooks are bound to change post-draft — and when they do, I'll send you an updated version of this guide — but it's never a bad idea to have a good grasp on a class before the draft happens.

(Psst: These outlooks were updated.)

Key Terms

Z-Prospect Score: The score — often in percentile form — given to an incoming rookie in the Z-Prospect Model. It's based on the factors outlined in the Z-Prospect Overview section of this guide.

B2S: The Z-Prospect Model attempts to predict how well a player will do in fantasy football across his first three years in the league. In doing this, it tests against the average of a player's top-two seasons in PPR points per game during his first three years as a pro. This is referred to as B2S (Best Two Seasons).

Draft Capital Delta: The percentile difference between a player's Z-Prospect score versus where he was drafted in the actual NFL Draft. Anything under 0 means the player was overdrafted, and anything over 0 means the player was underdrafted.

Speed Score: A concept developed by Bill Barnwell to help appropriately weight 40-yard dash times based on a player's size. In the Z-Prospect Model, anything under 90 at running back is a red flag.

Statistical Comparables: Players in history who appear to have similar analytical profiles to the player being analyzed. This is based on things like size, early-declare status, and production metrics.

Z-Prospect Model Cheatsheet

	Running Back				Wide Receiver			
Rank	Player	Team	Z-Prospect	Delta	Player	Team	Z-Prospect	Delta
1	B. Hall	NYJ	96.9%	1.8%	D. London	ATL	98.4%	0.4%
2	K. Walker	SEA	93.2%	-0.5%	C. Olave	NO	97.9%	0.7%
3	R. White	TB	85.4%	4.2%	G. Wilson	NYJ	97.4%	-0.2%
4	J. Cook	BUF	83.1%	-4.4%	T. Burks	TEN	95.3%	-0.2%
5	B. Robinson	WAS	72.1%	-6.8%	J. Williams	DET	95.1%	-1.9%
6	T. Allgeier	ATL	70.1%	7.6%	J. Dotson	WAS	94.2%	-1.6%
7	T. Badie	BAL	68.8%	18.2%	W. Robinson	NYG	92.6%	4.4%
8	D. Pierce	HOU	68.0%	-8.9%	S. Moore	KC	85.5%	0.4%
9	T. Davis-Price	SF	67.4%	-13.5%	J. Metchie	HOU	85.1%	-2.8%
10	K. Harris	NE	66.7%	12.8%	C. Watson	GB	83.5%	-7.4%
11	H. Haskins	TEN	64.6%	-3.9%	G. Pickens	PIT	82.5%	-3.2%
12	P. Strong	NE	62.5%	-7.0%	D. Bell	CLE	81.8%	9.1%
13	J. Ford	CLE	59.9%	-0.5%	T. Thornton	NE	77.8%	-8.4%
14	I. Spiller	LAC	58.6%	-13.3%	A. Pierce	IND	77.2%	-8.2%
15	Z. White	LV	58.1%	-14.3%	J. Tolbert	DAL	74.8%	-0.4%
16	T. Chandler	MIN	55.2%	-3.1%	K. Shakir	BUF	67.8%	6.7%
17	S. Conner	JAX	52.3%	-9.1%	R. Doubs	GB	66.0%	1.6%
18	K. Ingram	ARI	50.5%	1.0%	V. Jones	CHI	61.5%	-18.2%
19	K. Williams	LAR	50.0%	-8.9%	E. Ezukanma	MIA	53.2%	-12.6%
20	I. Pacheco	KC	48.2%	10.4%	J. Nailor	MIN	52.7%	2.6%
21	T. Ebner	CHI	47.4%	-0.8%	C. Austin	PIT	49.6%	-13.7%
22	M. Borghi	N/A	44.5%	8.3%	K. Philips	TEN	49.0%	-9.1%
23	S. McCormick	N/A	41.9%	5.7%	B. Melton	SEA	45.2%	3.2%
24	T. Goodson	N/A	40.6%	4.4%	D. Gray	SF	42.2%	-29.1%
25	L. Brown	N/A	35.2%	-1.0%	M. Polk	N/A	37.3%	2.3%

Running Back (Best Single-Season PPR PPG; Years 1-3)

Percentile	< 10	> 10	> 12	> 14	> 16	> 18	> 20
95-100	21%	79%	71%	71%	57%	43%	36%
90-95	31%	69%	69%	31%	31%	13%	6%
85-90	19%	81%	63%	44%	25%	19%	13%
80-85	31%	69%	46%	31%	23%	15%	15%
75-80	69%	31%	25%	19%	6%	6%	0%
70-75	56%	44%	25%	13%	6%	6%	6%
65-70	85%	15%	0%	0%	0%	0%	0%
60-65	64%	36%	14%	14%	0%	0%	0%

Wide Receiver (Best Single-Season PPR PPG; Years 1-3)

Percentile	< 10	> 10	> 12	> 14	> 16	> 18	> 20
95-100	18%	82%	65%	53%	35%	35%	12%
90-95	47%	53%	42%	32%	16%	11%	5%
85-90	22%	78%	56%	44%	28%	17%	11%
80-85	45%	55%	40%	30%	25%	10%	0%
75-80	71%	29%	18%	18%	12%	6%	0%
70-75	82%	18%	14%	14%	5%	0%	0%
65-70	90%	10%	0%	0%	0%	0%	0%
60-65	87%	13%	4%	4%	0%	0%	0%

Note: Table values will change when players are drafted, as existing player percentile rankings can change.

Post-Draft Rankings Cheatsheet

Single-QB Top-48	Position	Tier	**Superflex Top-48**	Position	Tier
Breece Hall	RB	1	Breece Hall	RB	1
Drake London	WR	1	Drake London	WR	1
Treylon Burks	WR	2	Treylon Burks	WR	2
Chris Olave	WR	2	Chris Olave	WR	2
Garrett Wilson	WR	2	Garrett Wilson	WR	2
Jameson Williams	WR	2	Jameson Williams	WR	2
Kenneth Walker	RB	2	Kenneth Walker	RB	2
Skyy Moore	WR	3	Kenny Pickett	QB	2
Jahan Dotson	WR	3	Skyy Moore	WR	3
Christian Watson	WR	4	Jahan Dotson	WR	3
George Pickens	WR	4	Christian Watson	WR	4
John Metchie	WR	5	George Pickens	WR	4
David Bell	WR	5	John Metchie	WR	5
James Cook	RB	5	David Bell	WR	5
Dameon Pierce	RB	6	James Cook	RB	5
Trey McBride	TE	6	Malik Willis	QB	5
Wan'Dale Robinson	WR	6	Matt Corral	QB	5
Rachaad White	RB	6	Desmond Ridder	QB	5
Jalen Tolbert	WR	6	Dameon Pierce	RB	6
Alec Pierce	WR	6	Trey McBride	TE	6
Tyquan Thornton	WR	7	Wan'Dale Robinson	WR	6
Khalil Shakir	WR	7	Rachaad White	RB	6
Tyler Allgeier	RB	8	Jalen Tolbert	WR	6
Isaiah Spiller	RB	8	Alec Pierce	WR	6
Zamir White	RB	9	Tyquan Thornton	WR	7
Ty Davis-Price	RB	9	Khalil Shakir	WR	7
Romeo Doubs	WR	9	Tyler Allgeier	RB	8
Brian Robinson	RB	9	Isaiah Spiller	RB	8
Kenny Pickett	QB	9	Zamir White	RB	9
Calvin Austin	WR	10	Ty Davis-Price	RB	9
Kyle Philips	WR	10	Romeo Doubs	WR	9
Isaih Pacheco	RB	10	Brian Robinson	RB	9
Keaontay Ingram	RB	10	Sam Howell	QB	9
Jerome Ford	RB	10	Calvin Austin	WR	10
Hassan Haskins	RB	10	Kyle Philips	WR	10
Jelani Woods	TE	10	Isaih Pacheco	RB	10
Pierre Strong	RB	11	Keaontay Ingram	RB	10
Kevin Harris	RB	11	Jerome Ford	RB	10
Velus Jones	WR	12	Hassan Haskins	RB	10
Justyn Ross	WR	12	Jelani Woods	TE	10
Malik Willis	QB	13	Pierre Strong	RB	11
Matt Corral	QB	13	Kevin Harris	RB	11
Desmond Ridder	QB	13	Velus Jones	WR	12
Erik Ezukanma	WR	14	Justyn Ross	WR	12
Tyler Badie	RB	14	Erik Ezukanma	WR	14
Greg Dulcich	TE	14	Tyler Badie	RB	14
Jalen Nailor	WR	14	Greg Dulcich	TE	14
Jeremy Ruckert	TE	15	Jalen Nailor	WR	14

Breece Hall

RB • Iowa State Cyclones (New York Jets)

96.9%	+1.8%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’11”**
Weight:	**217**
Statistical Comparables:	**Rashaad Penny** **Ezekiel Elliott** **Dalvin Cook**

Update: Breece Hall was predictably the top running back selection in this year’s draft, and he’s looking great in the Z-Prospect Model. The Jets may not look like an ideal landing spot on paper, but what was the expectation? There aren’t many high-end teams in football with a running back need, after all.

There’s little reason to worry about Michael Carter, too. Hall is an every-down back with excellent athletic measurables who will command a large share of work in any offense he’s in. While Carter is a fine player, he always profiled more as a change-of-pace back in the NFL who could come through if there was an injury to his team’s starter.

Hall was second in this running back class in Speed Score, second in best-season total touchdown share, and second in best-season total yards per team play. And he had a top-season reception share of 11.5% — there are no concerns about his ability as a pass-catcher.

A near 97th percentile ranking places Hall in good company. Since 2011, 36% of running backs in the 95th to 100th percentile range gave us a high-end RB1 season in fantasy points per game across their first three years in the league.

Breece Hall has a legitimate chance to be a stud.

Isaiah Spiller

RB • Texas A&M Aggies (Los Angeles Chargers)

58.6%	-13.3%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’0”**
Weight:	**217**
Statistical Comparables:	**Miles Sanders** **Joe Mixon** **Todd Gurley**

Update: Isaiah Spiller’s pre-draft process was not ideal, and there are two main reasons he fell dramatically within the Z-Prospect Model since you last read this thing.

The first is draft capital. Spiller went from potential second-round pick to being taken in the middle of the fourth. That alone will shift his score a whole lot, giving him a worse chance to succeed in fantasy football.

A huge reason for that is likely the second item, which is his pre-draft testing. Spiller isn’t a great athlete, and at his Pro Day, he ran a 4.64 40-yard dash.

That presents a problem for the Z-Prospect Model.

As you read previously, a running back needs to hit a Speed Score threshold of 90 in order to not get hurt in the model. With Spiller’s Pro Day time, he’s *just* over that mark. However, the model historically adjusts Pro Day times — which have typically favored the player — in order to have a fair baseline across the position.

With Spiller’s *adjusted* 40 time, he gets an 89.7 Speed Score. And given the volatility in this section of the rankings, that drops his overall Z-Prospect score a heck of a lot.

You can think of it this way: had Spiller come in with a Speed Score over 90, he would’ve been in the low 70s in Z-Prospect score. That would’ve made him the model’s RB5. If you’re high on the landing spot and think he’s better than others do, you can treat him as such. It just wouldn’t make much sense to place him above players like James Cook, Rachaad White, or even Dameon Pierce.

Kenneth Walker

RB • Michigan State Spartans (Seattle Seahawks)

93.2% Z-Prospect Score	**-0.5%** Draft Capital Delta
Height:	**5'9"**
Weight:	**211**
Statistical Comparables:	**Tre Mason** **Darrell Henderson** **Nick Chubb**

Update: Kenneth Walker is *so* Pete Carroll.

The Seahawks took Walker in the second round of the draft despite a glaring number of needs, but we shouldn't be surprised. This is Seattle's M.O.

They love their running backs.

And they're getting a really good one in Kenneth Walker. He's fifth in this class in best-season total yards per team play, and that's with a really poor receiving profile. He's probably the best pure runner of the group.

But that receiving profile is scary, and it's what separates Walker from Breece Hall. Since 2011 and before this draft, we'd seen 17 running backs drafted in the top-100 and outside the first round who had a best-season reception share that was under 8%. Kenneth Walker, for the record, was at 5.4%.

Over the first three years of those players' careers, none of them had a single season above 16 PPR points per game. None. Zero percent.

When looking at the alternative group — the players who *did* hit an 8% reception share — that number shot up to over 30%.

The backs who were able to hit that reception share threshold performed better at every points per game level, but it was most significant when looking at ceiling. That's the fear with Walker. He should be a rock-solid RB2, but will he ever be a top-6 running back in dynasty?

Kyren Williams

RB • Notre Dame Fighting Irish (Los Angeles Rams)

50.0%	-8.9%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5'9"**
Weight:	**194**
Statistical Comparables:	**Theo Riddick** **Ito Smith** **Mark Walton**

No running back or wide receiver tanked his draft stock more at the NFL Combine than Kyren Williams. In my opinion, at least.

Williams was looking decent in the Z-Prospect Model before the events in Indianapolis, and then he weighed in at 194 pounds. We knew he was small, but there was hope he'd get to 200.

Then the 40-yard dash happened. Williams ran an unofficial 4.72 on his first try, and then he followed it up with a 4.70. His *official* time ended up being a 4.65, but that still gave him the lowest Speed Score in this draft class.

That's a problem. Williams' Speed Score of 83.0 puts him in a group of running backs that simply haven't produced at the NFL level. In the Z-Prospect Model, it's tough to find many hits with that type of weight-adjusted speed.

So despite his strong 15.2% reception share, Williams went from interesting to completely unattractive in a 24-hour period.

Rachaad White

RB • Arizona State Sun Devils (Tampa Bay Buccaneers)

85.4%	+4.2%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’0”**
Weight:	**214**
Statistical Comparables:	**David Johnson** **Jay Ajayi** **Tevin Coleman**

Update: If you peep Rachaad White’s top comparable, you’ll see a running back you might’ve heard of before: David Johnson. You know who was head coach of the Arizona Cardinals in 2015 when Johnson was drafted? Bruce Arians. You know who’s currently part of the Tampa Bay Buccaneers front office? Bruce Arians.

Maybe Arians has a type?

Like Johnson, White’s got a super a strong receiving profile. He’s one of two running backs in the Z-Prospect Model with a best-season total yards per team play rate above 2.2 to go along with a best-season reception share over 20%.

The other back is Christian McCaffrey.

White can see some receiving work as a rookie, but he’s more of a handcuff in the short term with Leonard Fournette in Tampa Bay. There’s a chance the Buccaneers move on from Fournette in 2023, but it’s more likely to be 2024. That could really hinder White’s ability to break out early in his career.

Nevertheless, the model likes him quite a bit, so he should be on your rookie draft radars. We want to draft players over situation.

Tyler Allgeier

RB • Brigham Young Cougars (Atlanta Falcons)

70.1%	+7.6%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’11”**
Weight:	**224**
Statistical Comparables:	**Mikel Leshoure** **Derrius Guice** **James Conner**

Update: The Atlanta Falcons got a solid back in Tyler Allgeier. He didn’t get the Day 2 draft capital that we typically want for a running back, but he landed in a backfield where he could do damage right away.

At 224 pounds, Allgeier is the third-heaviest back in this class. Bigger backs who aren’t highly touted will typically have poor receiving profiles, but not Allgeier — he’s top-15 within the class in best-season reception share.

Is he a super explosive home run rusher? Nah. As you can see from his comparables list, he’s more in line with what you get from James Conner.

Is that a bad thing in a wide open backfield?

With one of the best Draft Capital Deltas in the class, Allgeier is quite intriguing.

Jerome Ford

RB • Cincinnati Bearcats (Cleveland Browns)

59.9%	-0.5%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5'11"**
Weight:	**210**
Statistical Comparables:	**Darrynton Evans** **Lamar Miller** **Da'Rel Scott**

Update: The Browns seem like a bad spot for a player like Jerome Ford, but keep in mind that Kareem Hunt is a free agent next season. We know Cleveland will often deploy multiple backs in their balanced scheme, and with Deshaun Watson in town, the offense should be even more explosive.

Ford isn't necessarily someone my model loves, but as you can see by his Draft Capital Delta, it didn't hate where he was selected. He has an average profile overall with above-average athleticism. And a Lamar Miller comp could be worse.

This is just a general PSA: Don't sleep on Ford's landing spot.

Brian Robinson

RB • Alabama Crimson Tide (Washington Commanders)

72.1%	-6.8%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'2"**
Weight:	**225**
Statistical Comparables:	**CJ Prosise** **Roy Helu** **Mike Gillislee**

Update: The Commanders visited with a lot of running backs during their pre-draft process, and they ended up landing Brian Robinson at the tail-end of the third round. That backfield is now messier than it needs to be.

Antonio Gibson is still the guy, but Robinson has three-down potential. Washington probably wanted a player who could handle a big workload because Gibson hasn't been the healthiest back in the world since joining the league, and they got that.

Robinson's not a bad prospect overall. He competed with top-tier running back talent at Alabama, and that led to him not breaking out until his 2021 campaign. That also led to him being older prospect, having just turned 23 in March.

But he had some production in every season of his collegiate career alongside that stiff competition. That's at least a good sign.

Robinson should be viewed as a handcuff for now, but the potential is there if Washington loses trust in Gibson. There are only a handful of players in this class who profile as a traditional three-down back. He's one of them.

Tyler Badie

RB • Missouri Tigers (Baltimore Ravens)

68.8%	+18.2%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5'8"**
Weight:	**197**
Statistical Comparables:	**Eno Benjamin** **Jeremy McNichols** **Aaron Jones**

Update: This stat was noted in the previous version of the guide, but let's run it back:

Badie is one of five running backs in the Z-Prospect Model since 2011 with a best-season total touchdown share above 45%, a best-season reception share north of 18%, and a best-season total yards per team play rate over 2.1.

The other four? Well, two of them are Jacquizz Rodgers and Donnel Pumphrey. Both of them, though, had Speed Scores below 90, meaning they didn't have the athleticism to back up the production.

The remaining two are Christian McCaffrey and Aaron Jones.

Let's not make the assumption that an undersized back is going to be CMC or Aaron Jones, but the Ravens did get themselves a good player in the sixth round of the draft.

It would make sense to consider Badie in the final rounds of rookie drafts given JK Dobbins and Gus Edwards are coming off of major injuries, and the team likes to use their running backs. If you're in a shallower league, though, it may be tough to buy in. His score is still under that 70th percentile mark, and it's not like Baltimore is going to throw the ball a lot with Lamar Jackson. The passing game is where Badie could've really made an impact in fantasy football.

Zamir White

RB • Georgia Bulldogs (Las Vegas Raiders)

58.1%	-14.3%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’0”**
Weight:	**214**
Statistical Comparables:	**Alonzo Harris** **Joe Williams** **Chris Carson**

Update: Zamir White shared a backfield and dealt with ACL issues throughout college, limiting his production profile. His best-season reception share was just 3.4% while James Cook, who you’ll read about in a minute, stole the show as a receiver out of the Georgia backfield.

Honestly, the only real success we’ve seen in the model over the last decade with that type of reception share has been Derrick Henry. And we don’t want to bet on any player being Derrick Henry, right?

With that being said, White was a 5-star recruit out of high school, and he showed off his athleticism at the NFL Combine with a 4.40 40-yard dash at 214 pounds. That’s the allure with White.

We can at least find reasons as to why the math doesn’t like him very much. And landing with the Raiders is pretty interesting — Vegas didn’t pick up Josh Jacobs’ fifth-year option, so he could be gone in 2023.

The model may not love him, but White has some things working in his favor.

Dameon Pierce

RB • Florida Gators (Houston Texans)

68.0%	-8.9%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’10”**
Weight:	**218**
Statistical Comparables:	**Spencer Ware** **DeeJay Dallas** **Christine Michael**

Update: One of the top landing spots for a running back this year was Houston, and Dameon Pierce ended up being their guy at the top of the fourth round.

Pierce didn’t have a great production profile because he wasn’t given a bell-cow workload in college. Some will say that the coaching staff at Florida was just irrational, but it’s still a red flag. Good players get the ball in their hands, so why wasn’t Pierce fed more?

Pro Football Focus actually gave Pierce the highest rushing grade in all of college football in 2021, and he ranked in the 75th percentile in yards after contact per attempt. He’s a solid, bruising back with good size — that shouldn’t be debated — but his best-season 7.2% reception share isn’t quite where we’d want it to be.

Pierce’s situation feels a whole lot like what we saw with Samaje Perine back in 2017. Perine was drafted in the early fourth round to a wide-open backfield in Washington, and that boosted his average draft position in rookie drafts to the end of the first round. People were taking him over Alvin Kamara simply because of landing spot, when Perine, in the Z-Prospect Model, had a 72nd percentile score. Kamara was close to the 88th percentile.

There’s a good chance Pierce sees a lot of work during his rookie year, and he’s a fine enough prospect. There’s nothing wrong with liking him and drafting him at all. Just don’t let the lack of competition in the short term elevate Pierce above obvious sure things.

James Cook

RB • Georgia Bulldogs (Buffalo Bills)

83.1%	-4.4%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’11”**
Weight:	**199**
Statistical Comparables:	**Salvon Ahmed** **TJ Logan** **Prince-Tyson Gulley**

Update: JD McKissic was so close to signing with the Bills earlier this offseason before going back to Washington. That showed that Buffalo was trying to fill a pass-catching running back void, and they got their guy in the second round in this year’s draft when they selected James Cook with the 63rd overall pick.

Cook split a backfield with Zamir White at Georgia, so his production profile isn’t really complete. He did, however, post a 10.2% best-season reception share, and he ran a 4.42 40 at the NFL Combine. He’s explosive with the ball in his hands all while being arguably the best pass-catching running back in this class.

Cook definitely profiles as a satellite back, but he did weigh in a little heavier than expected at the NFL Combine, so there’s a chance we see him take more handoffs than anticipated in the NFL. That would really unlock his upside.

Now, Buffalo ranked 29th in running back target share in both 2020 and 2021. Fantasy managers may be hesitant about a player like Cook as a result. But the Bills haven’t had a back like Cook on their roster over the last couple of seasons. Expect that positional target share to increase in 2022, and expect Cook to make a receiving impact right away.

D’Vonte Price

RB • Florida International Golden Panthers (Undrafted)

29.7%	-6.5%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’1”**
Weight:	**210**
Statistical Comparables:	**Bilal Powell** **Chuba Hubbard** **Brian Hill**

Where a player went to school matters a lot less at running back than it does wide receiver, so the fact that D’Vonte Price went to Florida International and not Alabama isn’t a big deal to me. Partially because if it mattered, it would be reflected in draft capital.

And we shouldn’t sit here and expect D’Vonte Price to be a top-50 pick or anything. But he does have the right marks in his profile.

At 6’1’’, 210 pounds, he ran a 4.38 40, giving him a Speed Score that’s seventh-best in the class. His best-season total yards per team play rate is 1.94, which is great, and his best-season touchdown share (38.5%) and reception share (8.6%) are fine, too.

All of that combined brings forth a serviceable back, as you can see by looking at his statistical comparables.

Hassan Haskins

RB • Michigan Wolverines (Tennessee Titans)

64.6%	-3.9%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’2”**
Weight:	**228**
Statistical Comparables:	**Qadree Ollison** **Anthony Allen** **Dominique Brown**

The biggest back in this year’s class is Michigan’s Hassan Haskins. He’s 6’2’’ and weighs 228 pounds, and like most giant backs coming out of college, Haskins' receiving profile is lacking a bit. He did catch 18 passes in 2021, but that gave him a below-average 7.3% best-season reception share. That ranks 28th-best out of the 36 running backs in this year’s class.

Haskins only had one season at Michigan as a true workhorse, and he tallied a 1.50 yards per team attempt in that season. There’s nothing wrong with that, but there’s nothing special about it, either.

Haskins’ size is going to help him get drafted, but players with this type of profile — huge backs without special production — tend to flop. You can see that in action when looking at Haskins’ comparables.

Keaontay Ingram

RB • Southern California Trojans (Arizona Cardinals)

50.5%	+1.0%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'0"**
Weight:	**221**
Statistical Comparables:	**Brandon Wilds** **Rico Dowdle** **Sewo Olonilua**

Update: You're looking at a score with a pretty low hit rate for Keaontay Ingram, but there's definitely a possible positive outcome here.

The Cardinals took Ingram in Round 6 of the draft and, as we know, Arizona doesn't have that deep of a running back depth chart. It's basically James Conner and Eno Benjamin.

Benjamin had a better Z-Prospect score than Ingram, but he's now done very little — even with opportunity — since entering the league in 2020. That'll happen with a seventh-round pick.

Ingram is a bigger back who could serve as a more direct handcuff to the oft-injured James Conner. His overall production profile isn't super impressive, but at 221 pounds, a best-season reception share of 9.5% is nothing to ignore.

When you consider his size, the landing spot, and the receiving profile, you could do worse than Keaontay Ingram in the late rounds of your rookie draft.

Kevin Harris

RB • South Carolina Gamecocks (New England Patriots)

66.7%	+12.8%
Z-Prospect Score	Draft Capital Delta

Height:	**5’10”**
Weight:	**221**
Statistical Comparables:	**Jay Ajayi** **Robert Turbin** **James Conner**

Update: Kevin Harris has one of the highest Draft Capital Deltas in this year’s class because his profile is objectively great. He’s got the right size, and at that size, he was able to hit a 12% best-season reception share, something we rarely see from 220-pound backs.

To be honest, you could consider Rhamondre Stevenson a similar player to Kevin Harris. And, naturally, Harris is now Stevenson’s teammate.

The Patriots took both Kevin Harris and Pierre Strong in the draft, which seems like a mess (it probably is), but there could be some longer-term upside. Damien Harris is on the last year of his rookie deal, and James White could be out next year as well. All of a sudden, things could open up quite a bit for other running backs to get some production in the New England offense.

It’s admittedly difficult to cash in on Harris in rookie drafts now, but as a late-round dart where you can bet on the talent and see what happens with Damien Harris? Why not?

Sincere McCormick

RB • Texas at San Antonio Roadrunners (Undrafted)

41.9%	+5.7%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’9”**
Weight:	**205**
Statistical Comparables:	**Paul Perkins** **Jake Funk** **Trayveon Williams**

I’m being very genuine when I say this: Sincere McCormick’s profile is pretty good.

You see what I did there?

McCormick is another smaller-school back who had solid production marks in the Z-Prospect Model. The one spot to knock him may be on the athleticism side, since he turned in a Speed Score of just 91.6. That’s awfully close to not hitting the model’s threshold of 90.

But he got there. And the model likes him — at least compared to projected draft capital — as a result.

Abram Smith

RB • Baylor Bears (Undrafted)

21.4%	-14.8%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’0”**
Weight:	**213**
Statistical Comparables:	**Joe Williams** **Bernard Pierce** **Larry Rountree**

Abram Smith’s best-season total yards per team play rate of 1.81 is totally fine. His best-season reception share of 5.5% is totally not. Combine that with a below-average touchdown share, and you’ve got yourself a negative stat score in the Z-Prospect Model.

Maybe we can forgive Smith a bit, because the dude played linebacker at Baylor before committing to being a running back. Given that tidbit, it’s not a shock that he wasn’t able to do a whole lot as a receiver.

We’ve got to work with what we’ve got. And what we’ve got is a 51st percentile linebacker-turned-running back with mostly subpar production. To be honest, though, his statistical comparables could’ve been far worse.

Pierre Strong

RB • South Dakota State Jackrabbits (New England Patriots)

62.5%	-7.0%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’11”**
Weight:	**207**
Statistical Comparables:	**Elijah Mitchell** **Ty Johnson** **Da’Rel Scott**

Update: In the pre-draft version of this guide, the Pierre Strong profile was all about references to the fact that he looks exactly like Elijah Mitchell analytically. Both players had iffy production profiles, and they both slayed the 40-yard dash.

Strong landed in New England. It’s an unfortunate spot for 2022 production, but like it was noted with Kevin Harris, both Damien Harris and James White could be out of the picture in 2023. That’s at least a little interesting, right?

The Patriots also don’t have this type of speed in their backfield, so Strong is bringing a new element that could get him elevated sooner rather than later.

It’s tough to be in love with what went down in the draft for Strong, but long-term, things could still fall into place.

Tyler Goodson

RB • Iowa Hawkeyes (Undrafted)

40.6%	+4.4%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’9”**
Weight:	**197**
Statistical Comparables:	**Wendell Smallwood** **Ralph Webb** **Paul Perkins**

There are a handful of productive, undersized backs who could go on Day 3 in this class, and Tyler Goodson’s another one.

Goodson didn’t have a remarkable best-season touchdown share at Iowa, but a 26% mark will do. His best-season total yards per team play is fine at 1.68, and he had a best-season reception share of nearly 14%, which you love to see.

At Iowa, Goodson had decent numbers as a Freshman and Sophomore before really blowing up this past year as a Junior. The age-adjusted production is a plus.

Goodson measured at just 5’9’’, 197 pounds at the NFL Combine, but he fortunately ran a fast 4.42 40-yard dash to help boost his Speed Score to 103.2.

Honestly, if he was a little bit bigger, he’d be in a great spot. Thanks to his size, his comparables aren’t all that good(son).

Jerrion Ealy

RB • Mississippi Rebels (Undrafted)

27.9%	-8.3%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5'8"**
Weight:	**189**
Statistical Comparables:	**Marcus Murphy** **LaDarius Perkins** **Prince-Tyson Gulley**

It's *really* hard to find valuable fantasy football running backs who weigh under 190 pounds. In fact, the Z-Prospect Model, when dating back to 2011, hasn't seen a single success among backs under that size. Like, there hasn't even been close to a hit.

Jerrion Ealy, at 189 pounds, is in trouble.

Not only is Ealy small, but he wasn't even fast at the NFL Combine. For a smaller back, you'd want him to run his 40-yard dash in the 4.4s. Ealy did his in 4.52, giving him a Speed Score of 90.6.

He has a good 11.3% best-season reception share, and the hope for him in the NFL is that he can be a satellite back. That's not something you pay a premium for in rookie drafts.

Leddie Brown

RB • West Virginia Mountaineers (Undrafted)

35.2%	-1.0%
Z-Prospect Score	Draft Capital Delta

Height:	**6’0”**
Weight:	**213**
Statistical Comparables:	**Storm Johnson** **Joseph Randle** **Tim Cornett**

Leddie Brown was productive in both his Junior *and* Senior seasons at West Virginia, providing us a best-season reception share of 12.4% and a best-season total yards per team play of 1.60. Only six running backs in this year’s class were able to hit those two marks.

He’s got pretty good size at 6’0’’ 213, but he didn’t test all that well at the NFL Combine. That’s what takes his top comparable of Jeremy Langford (someone who at least had his moments in the NFL) to Storm Johnson (someone who didn’t).

Brown isn’t someone who you should be taking in the early or middle parts of your rookie drafts.

Ronnie Rivers

RB • Fresno State Bulldogs (Undrafted)

22.4%	-13.8%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’8”**
Weight:	**195**
Statistical Comparables:	**Ray Graham** **Ralph Webb** **Demetric Felton**

Kyren Williams had the worst Speed Score among running backs at the NFL Combine, but Ronnie Rivers had the second-worst mark. And he, like Williams, was under the 90.0 threshold.

That’s part of the reason the Z-Prospect Model isn’t a fan of Rivers. Other reasons are his projected draft capital, which is somewhere between late on Day 3 to undrafted, and his age, which is 23.

Rivers did have a best-season 17.8% reception share, and his best-season touchdown share and total yards per team play numbers are good, too. It’s the size, age, speed, and draft capital that’s really crushing him.

Funny enough, Rivers actually compares pretty favorably to Kyren Williams. He just probably won’t get picked as high.

Ty Davis-Price

RB • Louisiana State Tigers (San Francisco 49ers)

67.4%	-13.5%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'0"**
Weight:	**211**
Statistical Comparables:	**Jordan Scarlett** **Bryce Brown** **Chris Carson**

Update: Ty Davis-Price getting picked in the top-100 of the NFL Draft was a bit of a surprise. And then you look at who took him — the 49ers — and you just can't help but laugh.

Kyle Shanahan doesn't play by any particular rules with his running backs. And even if his team takes a running back with a Day 2 pick, it doesn't mean they'll use that player. We saw that last year with Trey Sermon.

The move to get Davis-Price seems to be one where they wanted to get a reliable complement for Elijah Mitchell. The biggest problem is that he, like Mitchell, isn't necessarily the best running back in the passing game. He had a 3.8% best-season reception share and caught fewer than 30 balls across three years at LSU.

The 49ers clearly see something. And because it's San Francisco, expect the unexpected.

CJ Verdell

RB • Oregon Ducks (Undrafted)

30.7%	-5.5%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’8”**
Weight:	**194**
Statistical Comparables:	**Nyheim Hines** **Marcus Murphy** **LaDarius Perkins**

The biggest plus to CJ Verdell’s Z-Prospect profile is that he produced immediately when he got to Oregon. In 2018, as a Redshirt Freshman, Verdell carried the ball 202 times for over 1,000 yards. It was actually his highest attempt total of his collegiate career.

He dealt with an injury during his final season last year, and he ended up weighing in a whopping 17 pounds lighter at the NFL Combine (194) versus his listed 2021 weight (211).

Verdell’s yet another undersized back (perhaps he puts on more weight down the line) in this class with a decent receiving profile. Maybe you feel better about him because of his age-adjusted production. That’s logical enough. He’s also got a pretty good top comparable of Nyheim Hines. But it’s doubtful he gets close to the draft capital Hines got.

Max Borghi

RB • Washington State Cougars (Undrafted)

44.5% **Z-Prospect Score**	**8.3%** **Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’9”**
Weight:	**210**
Statistical Comparables:	**John Kelly** **Armando Allen** **Eno Benjamin**

Everything is pretty ordinary in Max Borghi’s profile aside from his receiving numbers. His top season saw him with a 17.0% reception share, and that came back in 2019 when he was a Sophomore.

That was also when Mike Leach was coaching Washington State. James Williams, Borghi’s teammate as a Freshman, had multiple high reception share seasons under Leach, and he didn’t become noteworthy in the NFL.

That 17.0% number is probably at least a little inflated.

The Z-Prospect Model doesn’t know that, though, which is why Borghi’s prospect score isn’t all that bad. Borghi also has more size than Williams did — the former weighed in at 210 pounds at the NFL Combine. His higher BMI combined with his pass-catching ability could make him a nice PPR specialist for fantasy purposes.

Zonovan Knight

RB • North Carolina State Wolfpack (Undrafted)

25.3%	-10.9%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’11”**
Weight:	**209**
Statistical Comparables:	**Javon Leake** **Travis Homer** **Nick Brossette**

The one thing — probably the only thing — that stands out within Zonovan “Bam” Knight’s Z-Prospect profile is age. By the time this prospect guide is released, Knight will still be 20 years old. He turns 21 in April.

Age doesn’t really seem to matter for him, to be fair. As a Freshman at NC State, Knight played 12 games, ran the ball 136 times, and rushed for 745 yards. As a Sophomore, he ran it 143 times for 788 yards in 12 games. And during his third season with the Wolfpack, he had 140 attempts for 753 yards in — you guessed it — 12 games.

He started to do more as a pass-catcher during his second year in college, but the lack of progress brings forth some very average numbers in his profile. He’s likely just a depth piece in the NFL.

Jashaun Corbin

RB • Florida State Seminoles (Undrafted)

29.4%	-6.8%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5'11"**
Weight:	**202**
Statistical Comparables:	**Daniel Lasco** **Storm Johnson** **Evan Royster**

Draft capital probably won't be there for Jashaun Corbin, but there are worse profiles in this class. His best attribute is a near 12% best-season reception share, a number matched or exceeded by just nine other backs who were at the NFL Combine. His top total yards per team play season gave him a sum of just 1.31, though, which is a definite red flag.

There are actually a lot of similar players to Corbin in this year's class. Nothing about him analytically stands out, hence the mediocre comparables.

Zaquandre White

RB • South Carolina Gamecocks (Undrafted)

15.6%	-20.6%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'0"**
Weight:	**206**
Statistical Comparables:	**Kenyan Drake** **Michael Cox** **Justin Crawford**

Zaquandre White started his collegiate journey as a linebacker for Florida State before transferring to JUCO in 2019. After one year of junior college, he found himself at South Carolina, stealing looks from the aforementioned Kevin Harris in the Gamecocks offense.

White wasn't able to give us great production in a split backfield. Each production metric of his is below average, and his best-season yards per team play rate is under 1.0, a definite concern.

According to NFL Mock Draft Database, White's currently projected to be drafted ahead of his college teammate, which is tough for me to understand on the analytical side. Yes, White was more efficient per touch this past year, but Harris is almost two years younger, has better size, and played ahead of White in college. There's a reason efficiency metrics aren't huge in the Z-Prospect Model: they're not very predictive.

White does have an OK top comparable of Kenyan Drake, but I would be surprised if he had a Drake-like impact in the league.

Ty Chandler

RB • North Carolina Tar Heels (Minnesota Vikings)

55.2%	-3.1%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’11”**
Weight:	**204**
Statistical Comparables:	**Justice Hill** **Elijah Mitchell** **Jeremy Langford**

With lower-tiered prospects who have average production profiles — Ty Chandler fits that mold — you ideally want them to be good athletes. It can be a differentiator.

And that’s what we’ve got with Chandler. He did have a best-season reception share of nearly 11%, but his stat score is nothing special in the model.

On the plus side, he ran a 4.38 40-yard dash, giving him a 90th percentile Speed Score.

Like Pierre Strong, Chandler is a candidate to be this year’s Elijah Mitchell — Mitchell is one of his top-three comparables in the model. Will he have that big of an impact? Almost definitely not. It’s just good to see decent players hit a Day 3 pick’s comparable list.

Kennedy Brooks

RB • Oklahoma Sooners (Undrafted)

18.5%	-17.7%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’1”**
Weight:	**215**
Statistical Comparables:	**Larry Rountree** **Nick Wilson** **Travon McMillian**

A 3.8% best-season reception share won’t help Kennedy Brooks’ Z-Prospect score, but his best-season yards per team play rate of 1.57 is above average. He’s got pretty standard size, and he’s likely to be limited to an early-down role in the NFL.

It’s hard to find comparables for Brooks because of his reception share and yards per team play combination. Larry Rountree is similar enough, but his production was stronger in college. So think of Brooks as a lesser version of Rountree.

Trestan Ebner

RB • Baylor Bears (Chicago Bears)

47.4%	-0.8%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5'11"**
Weight:	**206**
Statistical Comparables:	**TJ Logan** **Cyrus Gray** **Johnny White**

Trestan Ebner seems like a similar prospect as Ty Chandler and Pierre Strong — AKA the guys who look most like Elijah Mitchell in this year's class — but he's got more issues to his profile than they do.

Ebner's 11.8% best-season reception share is really good for a lower-tiered player, but his best-season 1.17 total yards per team play is not. For reference, Chandler was at 1.47 in best-season yards per team play, Strong was at 1.52, and Mitchell, last season, was at 1.48.

That's Ebner's big red flag. He had a great Speed Score at the NFL Combine and is similar in size as those other guys, but he wasn't productive on the ground at all for Baylor. He only hit 70-plus attempts in one of his five seasons there.

Isaih Pacheco

RB • Rutgers Scarlet Knights (Kansas City Chiefs)

48.2%	+10.4%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’10”**
Weight:	**216**
Statistical Comparables:	**Damien Williams** **Alonzo Harris** **Karlos Williams**

Update: The running back with the fastest weight-adjusted 40-yard dash time at the NFL Combine found a home in the NFL, and it’s a good one.

Kansas City made Isaih Pacheco a Chief in the seventh round of this year’s draft, and given his +10.4% Draft Capital Delta, it looks like a steal.

Before this year’s draft and since 2011, only Leonard Fournette, Derrick Henry, Robert Turbin, AJ Dillon, and Jonathan Taylor have been selected in the draft while having captured a Speed Score of 115 or better and a best-season touchdown share of 35% or better. In other words, they moved incredibly fast for their size, and they did well in the touchdown column in college.

This year, Breece Hall joined that group.

So did Isaih Pacheco.

Kansas City starter Clyde Edwards-Helaire’s biggest issue in the NFL has been that he lacks explosion. In 2021, CEH was actually second-best in the league (minimum 100 carries) at gaining positive yardage on the ground per attempt. He was also last in the league at gaining 20 or more yards.

It’s that lack of explosion that likely led the Chiefs to sign Ronald Jones this offseason.

But what about Pacheco?

Oh, and get this: Pacheco’s top comparable in the model, Damien Williams, just happens to be another uber-athlete who thrived in Andy Reid’s offense.

Pacheco should be a top late-round target in rookie drafts.

Snoop Conner

RB • Mississippi Rebels (Jacksonville Jaguars)

52.3%	-9.1%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’10”**
Weight:	**222**
Statistical Comparables:	**Jonas Gray** **Spencer Ware** **Allen Bradford**

Some will like Snoop Conner for his size. He’s 5’10’’ and weighs 222 pounds, giving him the thickest BMI in this year’s class.

He just doesn’t have the production profile that we need for a successful fantasy back. His best-season yards per team play is just 0.72, and he didn’t have a single season with a reception share above 5.0%. He’d be a big outlier if he works out in the NFL.

Jaylen Warren

RB • Oklahoma State Cowboys (Undrafted)

32.0%	-4.2%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’8”**
Weight:	**204**
Statistical Comparables:	**Devine Redding** **Demario Richard** **Terron Ward**

We’re getting pretty deep into the running back list with Jaylen Warren, an Oklahoma State running back who transferred from Utah State before the 2021 season. Warren ran the ball 256 times for over 1,200 yards last year, but he still generated a fairly low 1.35 total yards per team play rate.

His production profile is one of the most average you’ll find in this year’s class. He has a beefier frame at 5’8’’, 204 pounds, but he’s not someone who should be on your radar right now.

Greg Bell

RB • San Diego State Aztecs (Undrafted)

24.2%	-12.0%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5'11"**
Weight:	**201**
Statistical Comparables:	**Jeff Wilson** **Tim Cornett** **Jay Finley**

Greg Bell has an awfully similar best-season production profile to the aforementioned Jaylen Warren, except he played for a smaller program and isn't on #TeamThicc. His top mark in the Z-Prospect Model is a best-season 35.0% touchdown share, but touchdown share matters least among the three production metrics.

When looking at comps, we do get Jeff Wilson, who's had his moments in the NFL. It's still highly unlikely we see Bell as anything more than a depth piece for an NFL team.

Treylon Burks

WR • Arkansas Razorbacks (Tennessee Titans)

95.3%	-0.2%
Z-Prospect Score	Draft Capital Delta

Height:	**6’2”**
Weight:	**225**
Statistical Comparables:	**Alshon Jeffery** **Allen Robinson** **Stephen Hill**

Update: The Titans shocked the football world during the first night of the NFL Draft when they traded away stud wideout AJ Brown to the Eagles. They followed the trade up by selecting Treylon Burks, a player many compared to Brown during the pre-draft process.

Making the assumption that Treylon Burks is AJ Brown would be foolish, but that’s at least the archetype Tennessee is looking at. At 225 pounds, Burks is the beefiest wideout in this year’s class. He’s a monster with the ball in his hands and can generate a ton of yards after the catch with his physical style of play, just like Brown.

The question mark is whether he can reliably get the football. Per Pro Football Focus, Burks played just 39 snaps against press coverage in 2021, largely because 77% of his career snaps came from the slot. You have to do a little more projecting for Burks than some of the other top receivers in this class.

But his best-season yards per team pass attempt rate is third-best among wideouts who were invited to the NFL Combine this year, and he exited the draft with a very solid 95th percentile score in the Z-Prospect Model. He’s not ranked as the WR1 in this class, but it shouldn’t surprise anyone if he ends up as that guy when we look back on this draft. There’s just more volatility to his profile than some of the other pass-catchers who were drafted in the first.

Drake London

WR • Southern California Trojans (Atlanta Falcons)

98.4%	+0.4%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’4”**
Weight:	**219**
Statistical Comparables:	**Tee Higgins** **Jordan Matthews** **Mike Evans**

Update: Drake London is the Z-Prospect Model’s top wide receiver in this class.

Why shouldn’t he be? He produced as a Freshman while playing alongside two productive NFL wide receivers in Michael Pittman and Amon-Ra St. Brown. He averaged 11 receptions per game during his top collegiate season, a number that hasn’t been matched by a single drafted Power Five wide receiver since 2011. He’s 6’4’’, 219 pounds and compared favorably to Tee Higgins and Mike Evans in the Z-Prospect Model.

London became just the ninth 200-plus pound early-declare wide receiver to get top-10 draft capital over the last 12 drafts. The others who fit that criteria? AJ Green, Julio Jones, Justin Blackmon, Sammy Watkins, Mike Evans, Amari Cooper, Mike Williams, and Ja’Marr Chase.

Not bad company, eh?

Landing on the Falcons isn’t necessarily ideal, but he’ll have a chance to capture one of the largest target shares among all rookie wideouts in Year 1 given the team’s wide receiver depth chart. With the situation likely only getting stronger post-2022, the sky’s the limit.

Garrett Wilson

WR • Ohio State Buckeyes (New York Jets)

97.4%	-0.2%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'0"**
Weight:	**183**
Statistical Comparables:	**Jerry Jeudy** **CeeDee Lamb** **Diontae Johnson**

Update: The reason Garrett Wilson was so attractive pre-draft was because of safety. He's just a really, really solid wide receiver who moves effortlessly to create separation across all levels of the field. And while projected draft capital was fluctuating for other receivers in this class over the last couple of months, it wasn't for Wilson. He was consistently mocked as a top-15 pick.

He went 10th overall to the Jets, where he'll immediately compete with Elijah Moore as the team's top wide receiver. And that's a little unfortunate. Both players rated *extremely* well in the Z-Prospect Model, and when players are good, they see volume. We'll likely be projecting at least 20% target shares for both guys over the next few seasons while they're still playing together on their rookie contracts.

But when a wide receiver has top-notch competition on his team, it can cap that wideout's ceiling. If there were concerns about Elijah Moore's potential, this would be an easier evaluation. Moore just looks like a stud. So in order for these two to really thrive in fantasy football — for them to hit WR1 seasons together like we've seen wide receiver duos do in the past — they'll likely need quarterback Zach Wilson to take a step forward.

There's nothing wrong with a couple of WR2s in fantasy, though, and given the current state of the Jets, that's a very possible outcome over the next three seasons. Wilson is still a nice option for risk-averse fantasy managers — the floor will be there because he's a talented wide receiver.

Jameson Williams

WR • Alabama Crimson Tide (Detroit Lions)

95.1%	-1.9%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’1”**
Weight:	**179**
Statistical Comparables:	**Calvin Ridley** **Jerry Jeudy** **Dyami Brown**

Update: Jameson Williams’ draft stock kept rising and rising during the pre-draft process, and everything came together when the Lions traded up to get him with the 12th overall pick.

Plenty of draft analysts had Williams as their top receiver in this class. He can separate from defenders with his down-the-field speed, and that ability fits well in today’s NFL. Had he not torn his ACL in the National Championship game, maybe he would’ve been selected ahead of Drake London.

Analytically, Williams has two concerns. The first is size. He weighed in at only 179 pounds, and while we shouldn’t oversell the importance of size at wide receiver, BMI does get some weight (get it?) in the Z-Prospect Model. He had the third-leanest frame of all wide receivers at the NFL Combine this year.

The other numbers-related “issue” is the fact that he didn’t produce until his Junior season. We can forgive that to a large degree because, before transferring to Alabama, he played with three stars at wide receiver at Ohio State. That’s just not always going to be captured well within a model.

In the end, Williams still hit the 95th percentile in the Z-Prospect Model, so it wouldn’t make sense to criticize anyone who still likes him as the top receiver in this class. The landing spot in Detroit may not be great in the short term, but Williams could also get off to a slow start given his ACL recovery anyway. If you’re able to get him in the middle of the first round of your rookie drafts, that’s a big win.

Chris Olave

WR • Ohio State Buckeyes (New Orleans Saints)

97.9%	+0.7%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'0"**
Weight:	**187**
Statistical Comparables:	**Will Fuller** **Zay Jones** **Devonta Smith**

Update: Chris Olave was a big draft-day winner. His projected draft capital back in March was in the mid-20s, but New Orleans moved up in the draft and ended up taking him 11th overall. As a result, his Z-Prospect Model score went from 94.6% to 97.9%, and he's now the model's WR2 within the class.

It's a little surprising that he edged out Garrett Wilson. Olave isn't an early-declare wideout, and Wilson beat him out in both receptions and receiving yards this past year despite Olave's extra year of college experience.

Olave did have a better Breakout Age than Wilson, and his best-season production metrics were stronger, too. That's why, with almost identical draft capital, he looks slightly better. Even without early-declare status.

The fit with New Orleans is fantastic. He complements Michael Thomas perfectly — Olave can stretch things out with his sub-4.4 speed, and that'll allow Michael Thomas to do his typical work in the short areas of the field. Thomas is also 29 years old, so Olave's not stuck in the same predicament that Garrett Wilson's in.

Reception Perception's Matt Harmon dubbed Olave the best route runner in this class. He's clearly a great prospect. There's no reason to be scared off because of his lack of early-declare status, especially considering none of his production from his Senior season is helping his Z-Prospect score.

David Bell

WR • Purdue Boilermakers (Cleveland Browns)

81.8%	+9.1%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’1”**
Weight:	**212**
Statistical Comparables:	**Davante Adams** **DeVier Posey** **Chris Godwin**

Update: After stinking up the NFL Combine, there was thought that David Bell wouldn’t even be a Day 2 pick in the draft. Cleveland made sure he didn’t make it to Round 4, taking him with their 99th selection.

The Z-Prospect Model loves Bell. He’s got the highest Draft Capital Delta of any wide receiver who was picked in the first three rounds this year, and that number is second-highest among wideouts selected between picks 32 and 100 since 2011. The only player ranked ahead of him is Keenan Allen, and the players ranked just behind Bell in Draft Capital Delta are Jarvis Landry and Tyler Boyd.

Interestingly, none of those players tested as superior athletes. They all were subpar ones during their pre-draft process. And, funny enough, Bell is sort of replacing Jarvis Landry in Cleveland. Given the way he used his body to make contested catches in college, it would make sense for him to play a slot role in the NFL. That’s exactly what he can do for the Browns right away.

The fantasy football market has been low on Bell since his miserable NFL Combine performance. He’ll probably be a strong value in rookie drafts.

Wan'Dale Robinson

WR • Kentucky Wildcats (New York Giants)

92.6%	+4.4%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5'8"**
Weight:	**178**
Statistical Comparables:	**Elijah Moore** **Tutu Atwell** **Marquise Brown**

Update: The Z-Prospect Model was bullish on Wan'Dale Robinson entering the draft, and the Giants didn't calm things down by taking him 43rd overall.

Robinson has arguably the best production profile in this entire class. No wideout had a better best-season receiving yards per team pass attempt rate, and Robinson's top season in receptions per game was an impressive 8.0.

The problem? He's small. He measured at just 5'8'' at the NFL Combine, and as the last version of this guide noted, the best wide receiver in the Z-Prospect Model since 2011 with that height (or shorter) is probably Jamison Crowder. (Tyreek Hill was that size at his Pro Day, but he's measured taller in the NFL.)

One of Robinson's top comparables in the model is Tutu Atwell, a small, productive college receiver who was selected in the second round last year. That's going to be at the top of a fantasy manager's mind when they see Robinson sitting there in their rookie draft. The size concern is very real for Robinson, but he's got a much thicker frame. He's not quite Tutu Atwell.

It makes sense to subjectively downgrade Robinson versus what the model is saying. The thing is, the dynasty community seems to be pessimistic about Robinson because of this size issue. In turn, there's a chance he's actually a nice value in rookie drafts this year, since managers aren't always reactive enough to draft capital.

So, yes, there's variance with Robinson despite a near 93rd percentile score in the Z-Prospect Model. But there's also a decent chance he's someone you should get a lot of in rookie drafts if his cost doesn't budge much.

Even if you go against the model, you can still utilize some math to beat the market.

George Pickens

WR • Georgia Bulldogs (Pittsburgh Steelers)

82.5%	-3.2%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'3"**
Weight:	**195**
Statistical Comparables:	**Nico Collins** **Tee Higgins** **Aaron Dobson**

Update: George Pickens' analytical profile is a little tough to figure out given the only full season he played at Georgia was when he was a first-year player. Injuries derailed his collegiate career, so his production numbers aren't great. His Breakout Age *is* great, though, after he led the Bulldogs in receiving as a true Freshman.

Many thought Pickens would go in Round 1, but he fell all the way to the Steelers at Pick 52 in the NFL Draft. The Pittsburgh offense is young with playmakers all over the field, and Pickens is unlikely to see much action in two-wide receiver sets as a rookie. But Diontae Johnson still hasn't gotten his second contract, and Chase Claypool saw a decline in performance in Year 2 last season. Don't rule out the idea that Pickens could be the Steelers' number-one wide receiver in 2023.

Pickens is one of few pass-catchers in this class who can play a traditional X role and produce alpha-like numbers in fantasy football. That's where the Tee Higgins comparison comes into play. We just can't make the assumption that he gets there given the incomplete profile overall.

Consider Pickens a medium-risk, high-reward selection in rookie drafts.

Jahan Dotson

WR • Penn State Nittany Lions (Washington Commanders)

94.2%	-1.6%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’11”**
Weight:	**178**
Statistical Comparables:	**TY Hilton** **Sterling Shepard** **Vincent Brown**

Update: Jahan Dotson going 16th overall to the Commanders wasn’t expected. It’s not that he’s a bad player — he’s top-10 in best-season yards per team pass attempt *and* touchdown share in this class. It just seemed like he was more of a fringe first-round selection.

That boost in draft capital moved Dotson from an 88th to 89th percentile wide receiver in the model to a 94th percentile one. He’ll play alongside Terry McLaurin for the time being with a questionable starter at quarterback, but the situation in Washington can change fast. McLaurin’s on the last year of his rookie deal, and Carson Wentz could be gone as soon as 2023 if things go south.

Dotson may not have the size to be an elite fantasy wide receiver, but he plays bigger than his 178-pound frame. And he might have the best hands in this class. Don’t underestimate him. And don’t overstate his situation.

Skyy Moore

WR • Western Michigan Broncos (Kansas City Chiefs)

85.5%	+0.4%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’10”**
Weight:	**195**
Statistical Comparables:	**DJ Moore** **Andy Isabella** **Jarvis Landry**

Update: Yes. Yes yes yes yes yes.

Skyy Moore is a Kansas City Chief. He gets Patrick Mahomes. We get fantasy football goodness.

As the pre-draft prospect guide said, Moore’s the only player in the class with top-season marks of at least 7.0 receptions per game, a 3.4 yards per team pass attempt rate, and a 40% touchdown share.

Take a look at the wide receivers to hit those marks while being drafted in the top-70 (Moore went 54th to the Chiefs) since 2011: Cooper Kupp, Tyler Boyd, Amari Cooper, Tyler Lockett, Jordan Matthews, Sammy Watkins, Allen Robinson, Andy Isabella, Devonta Smith, and Elijah Moore.

Moore’s a smaller-school player, and that always makes a wide receiver prospect iffier. Thankfully, he’s an early-declare wideout. Over the last 12 drafts, the only non-Power Five early-declare receivers to go in Round 2 have been Courtland Sutton and Davante Adams.

We’ll take it!

He doesn’t rank as highly as the first-round wide receivers from this draft, but don’t be surprised if Moore is the best Chiefs’ wide receiver in 2023. He’s got that much potential.

Khalil Shakir

WR • Boise State Broncos (Buffalo Bills)

67.8%	+6.7%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'0"**
Weight:	**196**
Statistical Comparables:	**Cooper Kupp** **AJ Jenkins** **Taywan Taylor**

Update: You couldn't have asked for a better landing spot for Khalil Shakir.

Shakir played a lot in the slot at Boise State, and he put together one of the most complete production profiles in this class. He's actually just one of four wide receivers in the group who had a best-season receptions per game of 7.0 and a yards per team pass attempt rate of 3.2. The other three to hit those? Chris Olave, Skyy Moore, and Wan'Dale Robinson, three players who were drafted in the top-60.

The Bills signed Jamison Crowder this offseason, but he'll be an unrestricted free agent in 2023. Isaiah McKenzie is there, too, and while he's flashed, he hasn't become a reliable threat out of the slot yet.

Shakir has a real opportunity to fit right into that slot role and play alongside Stefon Diggs and Gabriel Davis in one of the most attractive offenses in all of football. Considering the Z-Prospect Model likes him a lot, you should target him in your rookie drafts.

Jalen Tolbert

WR • South Alabama Jaguars (Dallas Cowboys)

74.8%	-0.4%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'1"**
Weight:	**194**
Statistical Comparables:	**Dede Westbrook** **Terrance Williams** **AJ Jenkins**

Update: The landing spot for Jalen Tolbert in Dallas is an intriguing one. It could signal that the Cowboys want to use CeeDee Lamb more in the slot, since Tolbert profiles as a perimeter wide receiver. So that's a plus for Lamb, but it's also a sign that Tolbert can find the field pretty quickly if things go well during training camp.

Small-school wide receivers get knocked in the Z-Prospect Model, and that's no different for Tolbert. He at least produced well at South Alabama, though, with the second-highest best-season receiving yards per team pass attempt in this year's class.

He's got a wiry frame, making the Dede Westbrook comparison an easy one. His second comparison is actually a former Cowboy in Terrance Williams, so maybe Jerry Jones and company have a type?

Overall, it's a great spot for Tolbert to go. Ranking in the 74th percentile doesn't give him great odds to truly hit, but no one is going to be expecting that in rookie drafts.

Christian Watson

WR • North Dakota State Bison (Green Bay Packers)

83.5%	-7.4%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’4”**
Weight:	**208**
Statistical Comparables:	**DJ Chark** **Kenny Golladay** **Mike Strachan**

Update: Christian Watson dropped into the goldmine landing spot after getting selected by the Green Bay Packers at the top of the second round. Given the team’s depth chart, he should be able to find the field right away.

The Z-Prospect Model doesn’t love him as much as a fantasy manager in your rookie draft probably will. The model doesn’t factor in specific landing spot, so you’ve got to give Watson a little more love subjectively, but there are certainly red flags to his profile.

Watson’s a smaller-school player with good-not-great production, and he’ll be 23 years old when the season kicks off. He’s also a non-Power Five wideout without early-declare status. Since 2011, we’ve seen seven wide receivers drafted in the second round matching that criteria: Anthony Miller, Zay Jones, Aaron Dobson, Titus Young, Andy Isabella, D’Wayne Eskridge, and Brian Quick.

That’s not the group you want to be mentioned with.

On the plus side, Watson is a crazy-good athlete with a lot of size, and sometimes that translates. We saw that recently with Chase Claypool. There’s just a lot of risk to this type of profile, because it’s clear that Watson’s stellar combine pushed him up draft boards. We should always lean on age-adjusted production over athleticism at wide receiver.

Whether or not you draft Watson in fantasy will depend entirely on your risk tolerance. The ceiling is there — especially since he’s got Aaron Rodgers throwing him the rock now — but the floor is scary.

Justyn Ross

WR • Clemson Tigers (Undrafted)

33.6%	-1.4%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’4”**
Weight:	**205**
Statistical Comparables:	**Terrace Marshall** **Nico Collins** **Bryan Edwards**

Update: Unfortunately, Justyn Ross’ medicals seemed to have pushed him out of the NFL Draft. It was just important to make note of that because he was once a really, really promising prospect. His elite Breakout Age paired with his size made him a George Pickens arbitrage play, but it’s too difficult to go after him now given the way the draft went down.

Romeo Doubs

WR • Nevada Wolf Pack (Green Bay Packers)

66.0%	+1.6%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'2"**
Weight:	**201**
Statistical Comparables:	**Tajae Sharpe** **Leonard Hankerson** **Kenny Golladay**

Update: It's no secret that the Packers need wide receivers. They took Christian Watson with an early second-round selection, and then they went back to the position in Round 4, selecting Nevada's Romeo Doubs.

Doubs can be utilized down the field. He ranked in the top-30 in deep-ball yards and receptions last season, per Pro Football Focus, and he was third in college football in deep-ball yards in 2020, trailing only Devonta Smith and Dyami Brown. He didn't run at the NFL Combine, but the Packers reportedly clocked him at a 4.50 40-yard dash at his Pro Day, so there doesn't seem to be any huge issues with speed.

In the Z-Prospect Model, Doubs has above-average numbers. His best-season receiving yards per team pass attempt rate is 2.79, a number well above the norm, and he averaged over 7 receptions per game during his top season. And he broke out before hitting 20 years old.

The Packers might be wanting to replace Marquez Valdes-Scantling with Doubs. If he falls enough in rookie drafts, he's fine to take a chance on, but ground yourself and remember that he still ranks as just a 66th percentile wide receiver in the Z-Prospect Model.

John Metchie

WR • Alabama Crimson Tide (Houston Texans)

85.1%	-2.8%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’11”**
Weight:	**187**
Statistical Comparables:	**Keke Coutee** **Chad Hansen** **Tandon Doss**

Update: Alabama wide receivers who were at least moderately productive in college are bound to get decent draft capital. That’s what we saw with John Metchie, who was selected by Houston with the 44th pick in the draft.

Probably the biggest issue with Metchie’s analytical profile is his best-season touchdown share. It was just 16.7%. Since 2011, of the Z-Prospect Model wide receivers who had one or more 15-plus PPR point per game season during their first three years in the league, just 5.1% of them had a best-season touchdown share that low.

And every player within that 5.1% had some sort of reason as to why the touchdown share was so low, whether it was due to off-the-field issues or injury-related ones.

It’s not the end of the world, but Metchie is likely going to have to be a decent outlier to have a truly high ceiling in fantasy football. He can be plenty productive as a consistent WR3, though. And if all goes well with his ACL recovery, he should be able to find the field immediately in this Houston Texans offense. Don’t underrate his ability to lift his dynasty value as a rookie.

Calvin Austin

WR • Memphis Tigers (Pittsburgh Steelers)

49.6%	-13.7%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’8”**
Weight:	**170**
Statistical Comparables:	**Tavon Austin** **KJ Hamler** **Rondale Moore**

Update: The Steelers continued to add to their wide receiver room on Day 3 of the NFL Draft, snagging Calvin Austin in Round 4. He’ll play behind the aforementioned George Pickens, Diontae Johnson, and Chase Claypool in the short term, but he could see some slot work in the offense as a rookie.

Austin’s a dynamic playmaker. He ran the 40-yard dash at the NFL Combine in 4.32 seconds, and he did a little bit in the return game as a Junior and Senior at Memphis, too.

His size is a big worry for fantasy football. It’s unlikely we see him really dominate touches, so he may be a better selection in a best-ball format where you don’t have to pick and choose when his inevitable big play is going to come.

Had he gotten Day 2 draft capital, maybe there’d be reason to be more bullish. It’s just tough to see Austin as more than a random spark in the Steelers offense. (And a Ray-Ray McCloud replacement.)

Alec Pierce

WR • Cincinnati Bearcats (Indianapolis Colts)

77.2%	-8.2%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'3"**
Weight:	**211**
Statistical Comparables:	**Chris Conley** **Amara Darboh** **Equanimeous St. Brown**

Update: Athletic wide receivers who lack production aren't beloved by the Z-Prospect Model. That's why Alec Pierce is tied with the lowest Draft Capital Delta among the 13 wide receivers selected in the first two rounds of this year's draft.

If you want to look at this optimistically, Pierce fell to a team where he's got a real shot to get into the game as a rookie. Indy's only reliable wide receiver is Michael Pittman. And Pierce's extreme athleticism may overcome the poor production profile. We have to keep an open mind: sometimes that happens.

But, uh, let's talk about that production profile. Pierce isn't an early-declare wideout. He's not coming from a big program, despite Cincinnati's success last year. His best-season receiving yards per team pass attempt rate was just 2.21, a number hit by more than half of the wide receivers in this class who were at the NFL Combine. And he also never reached a touchdown share of 30% in a single season.

The landing spot is above average, but the rest is below average.

Erik Ezukanma

WR • Texas Tech Red Raiders (Miami Dolphins)

53.2%	-12.6%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'2"**
Weight:	**209**
Statistical Comparables:	**Donovan Peoples-Jones** **Chris Moore** **DaeSean Hamilton**

Update: The only reason there's an updated writeup for Ezukanma is because of what was said about him in the guide pre-draft. To quote myself:

Ezukanma has good size at 6'2'', 209 pounds, and he's versatile. He played a little running back in high school, and could be deployed all over the field in the NFL. That uniqueness to his scouting report could get a team to pick him higher than expected in the draft.

Are we shocked that Mike McDaniel's team took a player whose skillset sorta kinda looks like Deebo Samuel's?

No, Erik Ezukanma is not Deebo Samuel. His production snapshot is not as strong, and Deebo is forever going to be nearly impossible to replicate. It's just a fit that made too much sense.

Kyle Philips

WR • UCLA Bruins (Tennessee Titans)

49.0%	-9.1%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5'11"**
Weight:	**189**
Statistical Comparables:	**Michael Campanaro** **Jarius Wright** **Amon-Ra St. Brown**

Kyle Philips has a negative stat score in the Z-Prospect Model, but not by much. He had ordinary tallies in best-season receptions per game and yards per team pass attempt, but his 10-touchdown 2021 resulted in a 43.5% touchdown share. That's impressive for a sub-190 pound wide receiver. He also had some work as a returner, which shows versatility.

Philips has the size of a prototypical slot guy in the NFL, and he played almost 93% of his snaps from that area of the field last year according to Pro Football Focus. The truest film grinders seem to really like his footwork.

So there could be something here. His production isn't bad, and he could have a specific role at the next level where he can thrive. That's something to always look for in prospects who are looking like Day 3 picks.

I'm sure some will make the easy comparison of Philips to Hunter Renfrow, but Philips' production profile is much stronger than Renfrow's was. Renfrow was actually a bit of an anomaly, but that happens sometimes with slot receivers. The production is why Philips' top comp is Michael Campanaro, a shifty player who had some moments in the NFL. Campanaro did test as a better athlete, though.

You'll notice, too, that Amon-Ra St. Brown is on the comp list. St. Brown's essentially a better version of Philips, but there are enough similarities that the comp deserved a shoutout.

To me, Philips has a chance to be a decent late-round rookie draft pick, especially if he finds a home that lacks a true slot guy.

Tre Turner

WR • Virginia Tech Hokies (Undrafted)

26.8%	-8.2%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'1"**
Weight:	**184**
Statistical Comparables:	**Ihmir Smith-Marsette** **Rodney Adams** **Trevor Davis**

We'll see this with a lot of players under the 50th percentile mark in the Z-Prospect Model: incredibly boring production.

Tre Turner's best-season yards per team pass attempt rate was 2.14. Meh. His best-season receptions per game rate was 4.0. Meh. His best-season touchdown share was a little over 23%.

Meh.

Turner's not an early-declare receiver, but his Breakout Age is better than most. The likely outcome is that he's a depth player at the NFL level. His comparables say that, too.

Dontario Drummond

WR • Mississippi Rebels (Undrafted)

18.2%	-16.8%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'1"**
Weight:	**215**
Statistical Comparables:	**Mark Harrison** **Gerell Robinson** **Jeremy Ebert**

There are things to like about Dontario Drummond when you see his profile. He has really good size at 215 pounds, and none of his best-season production numbers are below-average in the model.

So he should have a decent Z-Prospect score, right?

Well, not exactly. Remember, production isn't everything. Drummond went the JUCO route to start his college career, and then he played three years as sort of a big slot wideout at Ole Miss, where he was only really productive during his final season in 2021. That gave him a late Breakout Age, and he's now entering the league well over 24 years of age.

That age-adjusted production is a major red flag, and it's the main reason his statistical comparables are a bunch of wide receivers you've never heard of before. He has good size, but he'll have to be an outlier to be someone you use in fantasy football.

Ty Fryfogle

WR • Indiana Hoosiers (Undrafted)

22.6%	-12.4%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'1"**
Weight:	**204**
Statistical Comparables:	**Ryan Grant** **Bud Sasser** **Jester Weah**

A below-average Breakout Age is pushing Ty Fryfogle down in the Z-Prospect Model, but he at least has some redeeming production-related qualities. His best-season yards per team pass attempt rate of 2.47 is better than more than half of this year's draft class, and his best-season touchdown share of 44% is quite good. His last name is also Fryfogle, which gives him a bump within the model's "fun last name" metric.

(Please let me have some fun. I'm talking about prospects who may not even get drafted here.)

Fryfogle does have good enough size, but we just haven't seen many players with his profile become productive through the years.

Dai'Jean Dixon

WR • Nicholls State Colonels (Undrafted)

22.8%	-5.3%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'3"**
Weight:	**200**
Statistical Comparables:	**KeeSean Johnson** **Tony Lippett** **Ryan Grant**

Remember, smaller-school wide receivers get dinged in the Z-Prospect Model for playing against subpar competition. That's the case for Dai'Jean Dixon, who played at Nicholls State, an FCS school in Louisiana.

Naturally, if a player like Dixon got an NFL Combine invite, he likely did a little something in college. And he did. His best-season yards per team pass attempt rate is north of 3.0, his best-season receptions per game is a solid 6.0, and, last season, he scored over 47% of Nicholls State's receiving touchdowns.

Those are all very strong numbers, but that's to be expected at a lesser program.

Non-Power Five wide receivers who go on Day 3 don't typically have good hit rates, but at least the list of similar players has recognizable names. Overall, Dixon's a guy you throw a dart at in the fifth round of your rookie draft if he falls to a decent team.

Bo Melton

WR • Rutgers Scarlet Knights (Seattle Seahawks)

45.2%	+3.2%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’11”**
Weight:	**189**
Statistical Comparables:	**Mario Alford** **Shi Smith** **Kenny Stills**

Within the Z-Prospect Model, there’s not a whole lot going on with Rutgers’ wideout Bo Melton.

Melton has a decent Breakout Age, but he didn’t show off a whole lot of production during his five — yes, five — seasons at Rutgers. His best-season yards per team pass attempt rate landed at 2.02, a below-average mark in the class, and his single-season high in receiving yards was just 638. He did at least have a really high best-season touchdown share of almost 43%, which counts for something.

As you know by now, athleticism scores aren’t in the wide receiver model. That doesn’t mean we should, like, go after slower wide receivers. It’s just that other things are more important.

Melton, for the record, is not slow. He ran a 4.34 40-yard dash at the NFL Combine, putting him close to the top of this speedy wide receiver class. At least he has that going for him.

Charleston Rambo

WR • Miami Hurricanes (Undrafted)

21.7%	-13.3%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’1”**
Weight:	**177**
Statistical Comparables:	**Tre Nixon** **Alex Wesley** **Tevin Reese**

Charleston Rambo has a positive stat score in the Z-Prospect Model thanks to good best-season receptions per game and yards per team pass attempt rates. Where he lacks is Breakout Age, with his best season in college coming during his first and final season at Miami. He had played three years at Oklahoma before moving over to the ACC, and as a Sooner, he wasn’t all that productive.

Rambo weighs just 177 pounds at 6’1’’, giving him the second-lowest BMI in the class, ahead of only Tyquan Thornton. The difference is that Thornton ran a 4.28 40-yard dash at the NFL Combine, whereas Rambo was at 4.57.

There really aren’t many redeeming qualities to Rambo’s profile.

Reggie Roberson Jr.

WR • Southern Methodist Mustangs (Undrafted)

4.0%	-31.0%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’11”**
Weight:	**192**
Statistical Comparables:	**Kolby Listenbee** **Trevor Davis** **Keith Mumphery**

Look, we’re talking sub-25th percentile prospects here. There’s not much to get excited about.

Reggie Roberson Jr. at least has a Breakout Age. He did technically break out. But there are no positive production qualities to his profile, and he’s been legally able to go to bars in Texas for like three and a half years.

He didn’t run the 40, but Roberson is fast. There’s fortunately an attribute we can get focus on with him. The issue is that the Z-Prospect Model doesn’t care much for speed at wide receiver. That’s why Roberson is a near lock to have a negative Draft Capital Delta, since some team will probably buy into that speed.

Danny Gray

WR • Southern Methodist Mustangs (San Francisco 49ers)

42.2%	-29.1%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'0"**
Weight:	**186**
Statistical Comparables:	**TJ Graham** **Keshawn Martin** **Trevor Davis**

Update: The 49ers clearly wanted some speed, so they selected Danny Gray with the final pick in the third round of this year's draft.

It's not doing a whole lot for the model.

Gray is fast! He ran a 4.33 at the NFL Combine, giving him a weight- and height-adjusted 40-yard dash time that ranks in the 94th percentile in the model. That's the reason he was elevated to Round 3 of the NFL Draft.

It certainly wasn't his college production, at least.

Within this class (40 wide receivers who were at the NFL Combine), Gray ranked 22nd in best-season receptions per game, 34th in best-season receiving yards per team pass attempt, and 33rd in best-season touchdown share. The 49ers are likely going to be a run-heavy team in the immediate future, and they've got established weapons in the offense, making it harder for Gray to climb the depth chart. He could make some splash plays for them, but it's hard to envision a 41st percentile wide receiver in this situation blowing up in fantasy.

He at least has an attribute – his speed – to buy into. Maybe that's enough for a late-round dart throw in your rookie draft. Just don't have unrealistic expectations.

Slade Bolden

WR • Alabama Crimson Tide (Undrafted)

1.2%	-33.8%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’11”**
Weight:	**193**
Statistical Comparables:	**Quadree Henderson** **George Farmer** **Juwann Winfree**

Slade Bolden went to Alabama.

That’s the best I can do for you.

Bolden’s best-season numbers in the three production statistics are as follows: 2.8 receptions per game, a yards per team pass attempt rate of 0.71, and a touchdown share of 6.3%.

He then went out and tested like an accountant at the NFL Combine.

I’m sure Slade is a good dude. And maybe he gets reunited with Mac Jones in New England and they make some low-probability magic happen.

It’s just highly unlikely. The Z-Prospect Model has seen just a handful of players with a best-season yards per team pass attempt rate below 1.0. None of them have come close to a double-digit PPR point per game season across their first three in the league. It’s just very difficult to be into a player with such a poor production profile, even if he went to Alabama.

Makai Polk

WR • Mississippi State Bulldogs (Undrafted)

37.3%	+2.3%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’3”**
Weight:	**195**
Statistical Comparables:	**Geronimo Allison** **DeMarkus Lodge** **Tavares Martin**

There’s very little buzz surrounding Makai Polk, but he’s an interesting prospect. He transferred to Mississippi State after two years at Cal, and in 2021, he led the entire SEC in receptions.

Before you think he’s an obvious steal, a large reason for that was because Mike Leach’s Bulldogs led all of college football in pass attempts. Polk also saw a ton of screens, ranking top-10 in the country in receptions on screens according to Pro Football Focus. He wasn’t very effective per catch, leading to a poor receiving yards per team pass attempt rate of only 1.49.

But, hey, Polk’s an early-declare wideout with not terrible age-adjusted production. He’s probably not going to get the right draft capital to warrant any sort of high rookie pick, but he’s someone to keep an eye on given his early-declare status.

Tyquan Thornton

WR • Baylor Bears (New England Patriots)

77.8%	-8.4
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’2”**
Weight:	**181**
Statistical Comparables:	**JJ Nelson** **Titus Young** **Rodney Adams**

Update: Tyquan Thornton ranked really low in the Z-Prospect Model pre-draft, but that was largely because he was expected to go past Pick 200. The Patriots changed that when they took him 50th overall.

He didn’t quite get to the 80th percentile that we all should be looking for with these wide receivers, but his profile is interesting. New England really needed speed, and they got it with Thornton, who ran a sub-4.3 40-yard dash at the NFL Combine. He also had a best-season yards per team pass attempt rate of 2.60 to go along with a touchdown share north of 40%. He’s one of eight wide receivers in this class to get to those two marks.

He may not get a ton of playing time right away just given the veterans on the New England roster, but it’s a climbable depth chart. The Z-Prospect Model isn’t in love, hence the low Draft Capital Delta, but the market may not be all that interested in Thornton, either. Don’t rule him out in rookie drafts — a 77th percentile score isn’t a total death sentence.

Jalen Nailor

WR • Michigan State Spartans (Minnesota Vikings)

52.7%	+2.6%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’11”**
Weight:	**186**
Statistical Comparables:	**Conner Vernon Travis Rudolph Deontay Burnett**

Jalen Nailor’s best-season yards per team pass attempt rate came during his Junior season in 2020, where he averaged 2.13 yards per attempt. That’s under the average in the Z-Prospect database, and since 2010, only seven wideouts in the dataset who were drafted after Pick 100 hit 10 or more PPR points per game in Years 1, 2, or 3 with that low of a mark.

That’s just to say that Nailor has a 23rd percentile prospect score for a reason. He didn’t test as some exceptional athlete, and his comps reflect an overall uninspiring profile.

Johnny Johnson III

WR • Oregon Ducks (Undrafted)

11.6%	-15.1%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'0"**
Weight:	**197**
Statistical Comparables:	**Deondre Douglas** **James Quick** **Terry Godwin**

Once again, we're greeted with a wide receiver who isn't giving us a whole lot on the production front. Across five seasons at Oregon, Johnny Johnson hit 400 yards receiving just once, maxing out at 1.88 in best-season yards per team pass attempt.

He didn't do anything to help himself at the NFL Combine, either, with every pertinent workout metric ranking lower than the 30th percentile.

For now, I'll pass.

Braylon Sanders

WR • Mississippi Rebels (Undrafted)

0.9%	-34.2%
Z-Prospect Score	Draft Capital Delta

Height:	**6'0"**
Weight:	**194**
Statistical Comparables:	**Braxton Miller** **Kolby Listenbee** **Speedy Noll**

Some of the low-production, lower-tiered wideouts also didn't test well at the NFL Combine. Sanders at least was a little above average, and he walked away with a sub-4.5 40-yard dash.

The spreadsheets definitely aren't into him. He has a composite stat score in the Z-Prospect Model of -1.71, which makes no sense to you, but it ranks in the 3rd percentile.

No thanks.

Josh Johnson

WR • Tulsa Golden Hurricane (Undrafted)

20.0%	-15.1%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**5’10”**
Weight:	**183**
Statistical Comparables:	**Gabe Marks** **Dominic Rufran** **Patrick Edwards**

Just so everyone’s aware, when a player goes undrafted, he automatically gets a bad score in the Z-Prospect Model. It may seem unfair, but remember, we see loads and loads of undrafted players each year. Only a few — if that — will be remotely relevant in a given season.

Josh Johnson is not projected to get drafted, but his production profile is actually better than most in this range. He played at a smaller program, but he had a best-season receptions per game of 6.3, a best-season yards per team pass attempt of 2.66, and a best-season touchdown share of 40%.

Unless he gets drafted, he’s not someone you’ll likely need to worry about in your rookie drafts. An add if he finds the right team? *Maybe*.

Velus Jones Jr.

WR • Tennessee Volunteers (Chicago Bears)

61.4%	-18.2%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'0"**
Weight:	**204**
Statistical Comparables:	**Racey McMath** **Robert Foster** **Marquise Goodwin**

Update: Straight up, the most egregious wide receiver pick in the 2022 NFL Draft was Chicago taking Velus Jones with the 71st overall selection.

Jones has good size and speed, and he can play special teams. He'll also be used, at least, as a gadget player. But 71st overall? In this economy?

Analytically, Jones checks very few boxes. He's certainly not an early-declare receiver after playing six seasons of college ball. His production was so poor that he never really broke out, too.

The man is also going to be 25 years old in May. He's actually older than his new teammate, Darnell Mooney.

When filtering out all wide receivers drafted in the top-100 in the Z-Prospect Model since 2011, Jones' 61st percentile score is the fourth worst. His most realistic best-case scenario is a Marquise Goodwin-type career in the NFL, though an outlier outcome could be Terry McLaurin.

Isaiah Weston

WR • Northern Iowa Panthers (Undrafted)

6.3%	-28.7%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’4”**
Weight:	**214**
Statistical Comparables:	**Jazz Ferguson** **Allen Lazard** **Robert Davis**

When you get this far down the prospect list — when you’re looking at players who have a very small shot to make it big in the NFL — it’s important to just simply find interesting profiles. And Isaiah Weston at least has that.

He’s a Northern Iowa Panther, so he wasn’t facing stiff competition throughout college. You’d like to see a smaller-school wideout have better than a best-season yards per team pass attempt of 2.56, but that could be worse.

Weston at least has an impressive size-speed combination. He’s 6’4’’, 214 pounds, and he ran a 4.42 40-yard dash at the NFL Combine. That gives him a height-adjusted Speed Score in about the 97th percentile.

Maybe that’ll work in the NFL?

Kevin Austin

WR • Notre Dame Fighting Irish (Undrafted)

14.0%	-21.0%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’2”**
Weight:	**200**
Statistical Comparables:	**Emanuel Hall** **Chris Lacy** **Toney Clemons**

After Kevin Austin’s NFL Combine, we may see him with better draft capital than what’s currently being projected. If that’s the case, he’ll have a higher Z-Prospect Score post-draft.

Austin came in at 6’2’’, 200 pounds, and he ran a 4.43 40. That’s a really good number for a player that size.

The problem, of course, is that Austin wasn’t productive at Notre Dame. He led the Fighting Irish in receiving yards this past year (not by much), and his best-season yards per team pass attempt rate is below 2.0.

Perhaps Austin’s athleticism helps him out in the NFL, similar to what we saw with Chase Claypool out of this same program. The difference is that Claypool was far better of a prospect across the board. He was more athletic, too.

Mike Woods

WR • Oklahoma Sooners (Cleveland Browns)

13.7%	-34.2%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6’1”**
Weight:	**215**
Statistical Comparables:	**Marquez Callaway** **Emmanuel Butler** **JJ Worton**

It would be a surprise if Mike Woods gave you a lot of fantasy football production. During college, where he played at both Arkansas and Oklahoma, his best-season yards per team pass attempt rate was 2.18, and he never scored 30% of his team’s receiving touchdowns in a single season.

Players with those types of numbers just generally don’t pan out unless they’ve got some sort of special trait, but it doesn’t look like it’s there for Woods. At least football-wise — maybe he’s a good singer or something, I don’t know.

He’s projected to go undrafted, and this Z-Prospect Model score reflects that.

Devon Williams

WR • Oregon Ducks (Undrafted)

0.4%	-34.7%
Z-Prospect Score	**Draft Capital Delta**

Height:	**6'5"**
Weight:	**210**
Statistical Comparables:	**Mekale McKay** **Trevon Grimes** **Kendrick Rogers**

You'll be shocked to hear this, but there have not been any hits in the Z-Prospect Model at wide receiver among pass-catchers ranking in the 1st percentile.

The Z-Prospect Model does not like Devon Williams much at all pre-draft. He's got a seriously low stat score. In fact, we've only seen three wide receivers over the last decade hit nine-plus PPR points per game in one of their first three years with Williams' score (or worse).

With that being said, Williams does have good size that may interest a team or two. So let's wait until the draft is over before we say he's an automatic avoid.

(He's an avoid.)

The Year 2 Model

Overview

A couple of years ago, I did a *Late-Round Fantasy Football Podcast* episode called “Bailing on Unproductive Rookies.”

That show set to answer the following question: How much does a player’s rookie-season production matter?

The answer: more than you probably think.

It’s pretty rare for elite fantasy assets at wide receiver and running back to have done next to nothing during their first year in the league. Just take a look at today’s landscape — pretty much every great player in fantasy football was at least decent during his rookie year.

That alone told me that rookie-season production was probably good at predicting future production.

Thus, the Year 2 Model was born…

…a couple of years after producing that podcast episode.

For whatever reason, it took me a couple of years after that episode dropped to build a working post-rookie season model.

But it’s a thing now. Don’t worry. (I know you were really worried.)

Unproductive Rookies Episode

The episode I did about bailing on unproductive rookies was the main reason I had N’Keal Harry as a sell after his rookie year. You’ll win those trades far more often than you’ll lose them.

The goal of the Year 2 Model is to be much better than a player’s rookie-season points per game at predicting his second- and third-year production.

Like I just said, how a player performs during his initial year in the league is pretty telling. The dynasty world is going to like a player a whole lot more when he does well in fantasy football as a rookie.

What if you knew when to buy and sell those players?

The Year 2 Model — both at running back and wide receiver — incorporates a player's prospect score, some rookie-season production inputs, and his rookie-season points per game average to get a Year 2 score. That's the gist of it.

Everything in the Year 2 Model ties back to a player's max-season PPR points per game during his second or third season. So if a player scored 16 and 19 points per game during his second and third season, respectively, the model only cares about that 19 points per game mark.

As you'd guess, the Year 2 Model is a lot better at predicting a player's best points per game season in Year 2 or Year 3 compared to his rookie-season points per game average alone.

To me, this all is logical.

> If a player came from nowhere — if a guy wasn't supposed to be good, but he balled out during his rookie year — then there's more risk with that player than if an early-round pick did the exact same thing.

There's more risk with Elijah Mitchell going into 2022 than there is with Javonte Williams.

The Year 2 Model can help us out when higher draft selections underperform, too. Is Terrace Marshall, a second-round pick last year, doomed? What about Rondale Moore, who was OK but not great?

Similar to the Z-Prospect Model, there are easy-to-understand probability charts for the Year 2 Model.

	Wide Receiver (Best PPR Season; Years 2-3)						
Percentile	< 10	10+	12+	14+	16+	18+	20+
95-100	0%	100%	100%	88%	65%	59%	18%
90-95	11%	89%	74%	47%	32%	16%	11%
85-90	52%	48%	33%	29%	14%	0%	0%
80-85	52%	48%	17%	13%	0%	0%	0%
75-80	60%	40%	20%	20%	15%	10%	5%
70-75	89%	11%	5%	5%	0%	0%	0%
65-70	100%	0%	0%	0%	0%	0%	0%
60-65	95%	5%	0%	0%	0%	0%	0%

The Year 2 Model is straight up more predictive than the Z-Prospect Model. That shouldn't be much of a surprise considering we're working with actual NFL data, and we've gotten some sample of a player as a professional.

The wide receiver table above clearly shows that. Of the wide receivers since 2011 with three-plus seasons in the league who ranked in the 95th to 100th percentile in Year 2 score, every single one gave us a PPR points per game season of 12 or more in either Year 2 or Year 3. A shocking 59% of them hit 18 or more PPR points, which would've ranked in the top-5 in 2021.

That's kind of crazy, isn't it?

> Historically, a player in the elite percentile group has had better than 50-50 odds to give you a top-5 season in PPR points per game during either Year 2 or Year 3.

As you move from group to group, the hit rates predictably change. Wide receivers in the 70th to 75th percentile tier almost always fail to give you a double-digit PPR season in Year 2 or Year 3. Under that 70th percentile mark? Good luck.

It looks pretty strong at running back, too.

	Running Back (Best PPR Season; Years 2-3)						
Percentile	< 10	10+	12+	14+	16+	18+	20+
95-100	8%	92%	85%	85%	69%	62%	54%
90-95	14%	86%	64%	43%	36%	14%	7%
85-90	57%	43%	21%	21%	14%	7%	0%
80-85	83%	17%	8%	0%	0%	0%	0%
75-80	53%	47%	33%	27%	13%	13%	7%
70-75	54%	46%	31%	23%	0%	0%	0%
65-70	60%	40%	27%	7%	7%	0%	0%
60-65	69%	31%	23%	8%	8%	0%	0%

Over half of the 95th to 100th percentile running backs in the Year 2 Model since 2011 have produced a top-5 season in Year 2 or Year 3, finishing with 20 or more PPR points. There's some sample size noise happening in the 80th to 85th percentile group, but like the wide receiver table, things do generally get worse and worse with each tier drop.

The high-end running back numbers are undeniable. Betting on a 90th percentile or better running back seems like a good call. Below that, there's a ton of risk.

Journey Comparables

When you get a new shirt from a clothing brand that you've never bought from before, it's a gamble. You have no clue if it's going to fit right. It's a completely different experience than if you buy from a place you typically purchase from.

There may or may not be a point to this analogy. We'll see how this goes.

It's always easier to grasp a player's ability when we can compare what he's done to players we've seen in the past. That's tougher to do for some players versus others — for some players, it's like buying a shirt from a new clothing company. But having that type of context can really aid us in our decision-making.

(OK, that wasn't a very good analogy.)

Enter Journey Comparables.

You've probably already read about statistical comparables with the Z-Prospect Model profiles earlier. Journey Comparables are a little different. Rather than looking at a player's attributes as he enters the league, Journey Comparables inspect a player's Z-Prospect Model score along with his Year 2 Model score. It then looks at players in history who have gone through a similar path — a similar journey — from before Year 1 to before Year 2.

Journey Comparables don't deal with play style, height, weight, or any other qualities. It's simply a look at players in history who entered the league as a similarly graded prospect who then went into their second season with a comparable Year 2 Model score as well.

Other Analogy Possibilities

When writing this guide, I thought about going with some sort of restaurant analogy here instead of the clothing one. Either way, it would've been a poor way to explain my thoughts on Journey Comparables.

2022 Year 2 Model Profiles

Overview

If you were one of the fortunate ones who drafted Elijah Mitchell in your dynasty rookie draft last year, is now the time to trade him away? Is Kadarius Toney bound to blow up during his second — and hopefully healthier — season in the league? Are there any players from last year's draft class who are totally flying under the radar?

These Year 2 Model profiles can help answer those questions.

Over the final section of this guide, you'll read about all relevant wide receivers and running backs from last year's draft class.

> You'll see where the Year 2 Model has them ranked, and you'll get insight on how to manage each player moving forward.

You'll also learn about my biggest miss from last year's class.

Who doesn't want to see a fantasy football analyst get buried?

Key Terms

Z-Prospect Score: The score — often in percentile form — given to an incoming rookie in the Z-Prospect Model. It's based on the factors outlined in the Z-Prospect Overview section of this guide.

B2S: The Z-Prospect Model attempts to predict how well a player will do in fantasy football across his first three years in the league. In doing this, it tests against the average of a player's top-two seasons in PPR points per game during his first three years as a pro. This is referred to as B2S (Best Two Seasons).

Draft Capital Delta: The percentile difference between a player's Z-Prospect score versus where he was drafted in the actual NFL Draft. Anything under 0 means the player was overdrafted, and anything over 0 means the player was underdrafted.

Journey Comparables: Players in history who have had similar Z-Prospect Model and Year 2 Model scores.

Expected Max PPR PPG Season: The estimated outcome in best-season PPR points per game in Year 2 or Year 3 for a particular player. This is simply a median, so the number is likely smaller than expected.

Najee Harris

RB • Pittsburgh Steelers

97.8% **Z-Prospect Score**	**98.8%** **Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**20.8**
Journey Comparables:	**Ezekiel Elliott** **Leonard Fournette** **Christian McCaffrey**

Najee Harris exited the 2021 NFL Draft with the best Z-Prospect score among all running backs in the class, ranking near the 98th percentile. His total was boosted by an encouraging 13.3% best-season reception share and a best-season total yards per team play rate of 2.10, third-best among his colleagues.

He went one pick ahead of Travis Etienne, and that's what really gave him the edge over Etienne in prospect score. Unlike Etienne, we saw a whole lot of production from Harris in Year 1. After capturing over 85% of Pittsburgh's running back rush attempts and running for 1,200 yards, Harris actually looks better in the Year 2 Model than he did in the Z-Prospect one.

Ranking close to the 99th percentile in the Year 2 Model means that he's got better than 50-50 odds to give us a top-five season over the next two years. That's why you see his expected top season over the next two years sitting at 20.8 PPR points per game.

Given all of this, it's easy to understand why his top Journey Comparables are Ezekiel Elliott, Leonard Fournette, and Christian McCaffrey. Elliott in particular seems like the right type of player to think about when figuring out Harris' next handful of seasons.

Javonte Williams

RB • Denver Broncos

95.4%	94.3%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**15.1**
Journey Comparables:	**Dalvin Cook** **Josh Jacobs** **Clyde Edwards-Helaire**

Before the draft last year, the Z-Prospect Model liked Javonte Williams more than any other running back in the 2021 class. That changed when Najee Harris and Travis Etienne snagged first-round draft capital, but Williams still scored close to them in the 95th percentile. It's not like he was out of their league.

His rookie season was slightly disappointing as he shared a backfield with Melvin Gordon, but it's hard to be upset about 200-plus rush attempts and 50-plus targets from your freshman back. We saw him go beast mode as the main runner against Kansas City in Week 13, giving us a glimpse of what the future could look like if he's able to get the backfield to himself.

There's a slight drop when looking at Williams' Z-Prospect score to his Year 2 score, but the good news is that his Journey Comparables are pretty strong. His top one, Dalvin Cook, was also a second-rounder who saw a minor dip in percentile ranking from Year 1 to Year 2. Cook didn't really get going until Year 3 thanks to injury, so let's cross our fingers and hope that Williams can stay healthy and give us a great second season.

He's someone you'd absolutely want on your dynasty roster. While he misses the cutoff of being in the 95th percentile in the Year 2 Model, players of his caliber still have strong hit rates.

Michael Carter

RB • New York Jets

77.4%	89.9%
Z-Prospect Score	Year-2 Model Score
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**12.5**
Journey Comparables:	**Devin Singletary** **Devontae Booker** **Jeremy Langford**

You may recall, but with the Z-Prospect Model, we often see a big decrease in hit rate when a player drops below the 80th percentile. Then, with the Year 2 Model, that dip occurs at the 90th percentile.

Michael Carter is oh-so-close to both of those thresholds.

Don't worry, Carter truthers: those limits are a little arbitrary. It just would've been nice and clean had Carter been slightly better in college and slightly better as a rookie.

He had an underrated rookie year, though. Carter hit a 9.5% target share in 14 games, meaning he would've definitely been in the double-digit percentage range had he been healthy all year. And there's certainly nothing wrong with averaging over 11 PPR points per game as a first-year back.

The model really hasn't seen a running back quite like Carter before. His top comparable of Devin Singletary went through a relatively similar voyage — Singletary was an 81st percentile prospect who jumped to the 91st percentile in Year 2 score — and it's interesting that the two players have such similar builds as smaller backs. Remember, these Journey Comparables only care about model scores, not their actual profiles.

It's tough to see Carter as some full-fledged RB1 in fantasy football, but with a solid Year 2 Model percentile ranking and a decent top comparable, you can feel good about Carter at least being semi-productive moving forward. An RB2 ceiling makes sense.

Elijah Mitchell

RB • San Francisco 49ers

55.4%	86.6%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**11.3**
Journey Comparables:	**Zac Stacy** **Andre Ellington** **James Robinson**

Elijah Mitchell wasn't even the first running back selected by the San Francisco 49ers in 2021 (Hey, Trey!), but he sure was the most productive back on the team last season. Mitchell entered the league with a Z-Prospect score that ranked in the 55th percentile. That's not great, but he had a positive Draft Capital Delta.

Najee Harris was the only rookie back to average more points per game (17.7) than Mitchell (15.0) last year. That's it. And Najee, as we know, was a first-round pick. Mitchell wasn't selected until the sixth.

And there's the problem. Should you weigh rookie-season production most? Or should you be paying more attention to a player's prospect score?

Mitchell saw a substantial jump in percentile ranking after his awesome rookie campaign. It was one of the 10 largest shifts by a back over the last 10 years.

The downside for Mitchell is that we've sort of seen this story before. In 2013, Zac Stacy, a fifth-round selection, finished the season with 13.1 PPR points per game. That same season, sixth-rounder Andre Ellington averaged 11. James Robinson went nuts in 2020 after being undrafted, and he watched his team draft a running back in the first round the very next offseason.

I wouldn't fault anyone for holding Mitchell after acquiring him for next to nothing last year. He's a fun player. He's a talented player. And he works well in the Shanahan offense.

There's just fragility to these situations. The truth is, 8 times out of 10, when you sell a running back like this, you'll profit. That's evident when you see that he's in a percentile tier where just 14% of the players since 2011 have given you an RB1 season.

He can be an RB2, but odds aren't in his favor to be a foundational dynasty piece.

Kenneth Gainwell

RB • Philadelphia Eagles

70.9% Z-Prospect Score	84.2% Year-2 Model Score
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**10.3**
Journey Comparables:	**Javorius Allen** **Marlon Mack** **Tony Pollard**

It was easy to fall in love with Kenneth Gainwell during the draft process last year. Like a lot of recent Memphis running backs, Gainwell had a best-season reception share of over 18% in college, a mark hit by fewer than 25 running backs in the Z-Prospect Model database since 2011. Since the Z-Prospect Model digs receiving numbers, Gainwell had a Draft Capital Delta of 5.8%, ranking behind only Kylin Hill and Khalil Herbert in last year's class within the statistic.

He didn't go nuts as a rookie, but a 10.8% target share is nothing to ignore. His volume through the air is what boosted his Year 2 Model score to the 84th percentile, giving him a comparable Year 2 and Year 3 hit rate to Elijah Mitchell.

Mitchell undoubtedly has the higher ceiling — he's also got the higher expected outcome over the next two seasons, to be clear — but Gainwell isn't nearly as costly and has a shot to carve out a consistent receiving role in the Philly offense. He's one of my favorite buys this offseason.

Chuba Hubbard

RB • Carolina Panthers

74.1%	82.4%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**9.9**
Journey Comparables:	**Jeremy Langford** **Kenneth Dixon** **Andre Williams**

Most of us know the Chuba Hubbard story by now. He had a Sophomore season at Oklahoma State to remember, rushing for over 2,000 yards while finishing the season with a total yards per team play rate of 2.48. That was the highest best-season mark within that statistic among all backs in the 2021 draft class.

His final collegiate season didn't go nearly as well. He played fewer games, but every single rate stat plummeted. That led to him being picked on Day 3 of last year's draft.

And let's be real: Hubbard wouldn't have been a success in Year 1 had Christian McCaffrey stayed healthy. He would've seen some work here and there each game, but CMC had that backfield on lock. The injury allowed Hubbard to emerge, where he was…completely uninspiring. Among the 29 running backs with 150 or more rushes last season, Hubbard was fifth-worst at gaining positive yardage, and he was the absolute worst at gaining two or more yards per carry.

His Journey Comparables are interesting because they feature players who got some run during their first year in the league before flaming out. His top one, Jeremy Langford, carried the ball 148 times as a rookie, filling in for injured stud back in Matt Forte.

Sound familiar?

It's hard to buy into Hubbard as a result of the mediocre effectiveness he showed in Year 1 alongside weak comparables.

Rhamondre Stevenson

RB • New England Patriots

66.5%	79.4%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**9.1**
Journey Comparables:	**Matt Jones** **Jamaal Williams** **Vick Ballard**

The Z-Prospect Model wasn't very kind to Rhamondre Stevenson last year because his profile was pretty incomplete. He played junior college ball before transferring to Oklahoma where he carried the rock just 165 times. That lack of volume was largely due to a suspension for marijuana use, though.

When Stevenson was on the field, he posted good numbers. On a per-game basis, he was seeing upwards of 15% of his offense's receptions, something bigger-bodied backs don't typically see. That was the main reason I was cool with taking him in rookie drafts last year.

We saw a nice leap from his lower-than-it-should've-been prospect score to his Year 2 one. That's because he was effective as a rookie. Of the 49 backs with 100 or more carries, Stevenson was 11th-best at gaining 2 or more yards per carry. He was well above average at posting positive yardage per tote, too.

He's one of those players where it's just inherently more difficult to evaluate through this model. Not only was his college journey a little unorthodox, but the Patriots have historically deployed their running backs in unusual ways.

His Year 2 Model percentile places him in a bucket that has seen a couple of big hits over the last decade. Devonta Freeman, for example, had a 78th percentile Year 2 score before his breakout campaign in 2015. Stevenson didn't hit the elusive 90th percentile, but there are at least some reasons to be bullish about him moving forward.

Travis Etienne

RB • Jacksonville Jaguars

97.6%	70.8%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**6.9**
Journey Comparables:	**David Wilson** **Rashaad Penny** **Mark Ingram**

You've probably filed a missing person report for Travis Etienne by now, but don't worry, he's here. He's just a little lost.

My goal is to be an open book with all of this stuff. You shouldn't listen to analysts who just say, "Trust me! I know what I'm doing!"

You should want to know the why and the how.

The Year 2 Model has its flaws. One of them is that it can't tell if little or no production from a first-year player came as the result of injury or just poor play. For Etienne, clearly, it's the former. He missed his entire rookie season thanks to a Lisfranc injury.

These models are guides, not absolutes. And Etienne — and to some degree, Rhamondre Stevenson above — is a great example of that.

With that being said, his comparables aren't all that bad. They're highly-touted prospects who just couldn't get going at the start of their careers. In David Wilson's case, he unfortunately was never able to get going because of a neck injury that ended his career.

The fact that Etienne was a 97th to 98th percentile prospect should give us a lot of hope. Prospects in that range give us an RB1 season across their first three years more often than not.

Khalil Herbert

RB • Chicago Bears

55.7%	63.9%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**5.9**
Journey Comparables:	**Myles Gaskin** **Chase Edmonds** **Ty Johnson**

Was Khalil Herbert's Z-Prospect score really good? No, but it's impossible for it to be close to elite with sixth-round draft capital.

As I alluded to earlier, Herbert's profile was actually not bad — he was second-best in his class in Draft Capital Delta. The model was into him way more than the NFL seemingly was.

Herbert had a similar-ish rookie-season adventure as Chuba Hubbard, where he stepped in for a starter and, at times, carried a big workload. The difference between Hubbard and Herbert is that Herbert was effective. Not only did the majority of his efficiency numbers look better than starter David Montgomery's last year, but among the 49 backs with 100-plus carries in 2021, Herbert was 7th in percentage of attempts that went 20 or more yards. He showed off some explosiveness.

Take a look at his Journey Comparables, too. They're not all built the same — they don't all score points the same way — but they've been able to carve out roles after being Day 3 picks in their respective NFL Drafts. That has to count for something.

Herbert can be had for next to nothing in dynasty right now. He seems like someone who's worth throwing a dart at.

Trey Sermon

RB • San Francisco 49ers

79.3%	63.3%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**5.8**
Journey Comparables:	**Darrynton Evans** **Lamar Miller** **Christine Michael**

Rounding out the top-10 is everyone's favorite middle-round pick from 2021 season-long leagues: Trey Sermon.

Sermon lacked production in college and therefore didn't pop in the Z-Prospect Model. Did he have the right size? Sure. Did he have good draft capital? It was decent. Did he fall to an excellent spot? Most definitely.

The production just was not there.

This will read as a hindsight take, I get it, but it's not surprising to see a player like Sermon fail as a rookie. It doesn't mean he wasn't the right kind of bet in season-long formats, but he was a high-variance one. And that variance hit on the wrong side.

A Year 2 Model score in the 63rd percentile means that we're looking at about a 25% chance that Sermon's going to be an RB3 in fantasy football in 2022 or 2023. Roughly 70% of the backs in this tier fail to produce a single season in Year 2 or Year 3 of 10 or more PPR points.

I don't like Sermon's odds of bouncing back. At the absolute least, history tells us that there's very little chance he becomes anything more than an RB2.

Ja'Marr Chase

WR • Cincinnati Bengals

99.6% Z-Prospect Score	99.8% Year-2 Model Score
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**21.5**
Journey Comparables:	**Julio Jones** **Mike Evans** **Amari Cooper**

Do I even have to tell you that Ja'Marr Chase is a wide receiver deity?

Chase entered the league as a near-perfect prospect in the Z-Prospect Model. He then somehow increased his percentile rating after a rookie campaign that saw him average 17.9 PPR points per game.

On the comparables front, he was with elite company entering the league, and that's still true. His top Journey Comparable is Julio Jones, who came into the NFL as a 99th percentile prospect and stayed that way after his first year in the league.

The difference? Chase is even a little better than that on paper. As it stands, he, to me, is the top player in single-quarterback dynasty formats.

Jaylen Waddle

WR • Miami Dolphins

96.3%	98.4%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**17.7**
Journey Comparables:	**Justin Jefferson** **Brandin Cooks** **Calvin Ridley**

Like I talked through earlier, Jaylen Waddle was a case where it was logical to add some subjectivity to his evaluation. His college production profile was lacking for an early first-round pick, but there was also plenty of reason for it.

Because of that, his Z-Prospect score was lower than it should have been. Objectively. And we saw why during his rookie season after he caught 104 freaking passes.

His leap from being an incredibly good prospect to being an absolutely elite wideout entering Year 2 isn't totally normal. Just a year ago, we watched Justin Jefferson go from a 95th percentile receiver all the way to a 99th percentile one. Brandin Cooks, meanwhile, went from the 95th percentile to the 98th.

Waddle is somewhere between the two of them when looking at Journey Comparables.

Putting that bluntly: Jaylen Waddle is a star.

Devonta Smith

WR • Philadelphia Eagles

98.9%	98.0%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**16.5**
Journey Comparables:	**Sammy Watkins** **DJ Moore** **Jerry Jeudy**

It feels like Devonta Smith's rookie season has gone a little unnoticed, doesn't it? There was an extra game for players in the regular season this past year, but even still, Smith became one of 28 rookie wide receivers since the merger to hit 60 receptions, 900 yards, and 5 touchdowns. He didn't go nuts, but he was the opposite of bad.

Looking strictly at the models, the only problem for Smith is that he got worse year over year. He came into the league with almost a 99th percentile prospect score, and that dropped to the 98th percentile in his Year 2 tally.

It's tough to find players who followed an identical path, but all three Journey Comparables saw something similar happen. They each entered the NFL with a Z-Prospect score in at least the 97th percentile, and they watched it dip after their rookie performance. They're still relatively good comps, but they're nowhere close to what we're getting with Chase and Waddle.

Do keep in mind that wide receivers in the 95th to 100th percentile in the Year 2 Model have very good hit rates. I mean, *very* good. We've got 17 wide receivers in this tier since 2011, and of those 17 pass-catchers, all have given you at least one season in either Year 2 or Year 3 with 12 or more PPR points per game. It would be shocking if Devonta Smith just completely busts.

Elijah Moore

WR • New York Jets

95.6%	96.6%
Z-Prospect Score	Year-2 Model Score
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**15.7**
Journey Comparables:	**CeeDee Lamb** **Jordan Matthews** **Calvin Ridley**

Things were a little bumpy at the start, but Elijah Moore's rookie season was a success. He wasn't able to stay healthy down the stretch, but he averaged 12.6 PPR points per game across the season. That number was 17.7 specifically after the Jets' Week 6 bye.

My only hesitation with Moore as a prospect had nothing to do with the Z-Prospect Model. It was more utilization-focused. We didn't have a large sample size of him playing on the perimeter against press coverage, and if he was forced to the slot in the NFL, it had a chance to limit his ceiling in fantasy football.

Fortunately, that question mark is long gone. According to Pro Football Focus, Moore played just 28% of his snaps from the slot in 2021. He was productive on the outside.

The sky's the limit for Moore. Like the players above him on this Year 2 Model rankings list, he's got strong odds to become at least a WR2 in fantasy football over the next two seasons. He's someone I'd strongly consider trading for this offseason.

Rashod Bateman

WR • Baltimore Ravens

96.3%	94.0%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**13.4**
Journey Comparables:	**Corey Coleman** **Jerry Jeudy** **DeAndre Hopkins**

Rashod Bateman's Journey Comparables are all over the place because his rookie season was kind of all over the place.

He was beloved by the numbers-driven fantasy football community thanks to really good college production numbers. If you look at the three that the Z-Prospect Model analyzes, among all wide receivers in last year's class, Bateman was eighth in best-season receptions per game, fifth in best-season receiving yards per team pass attempt, and 23rd in best-season touchdown share.

Bateman's rookie-season production was a little sporadic. When he stepped onto the field for the first time in Week 6, he immediately saw a 22% target share in Baltimore's offense. He consistently was in the high teens in target share for the next few weeks, but down the stretch, he had a handful of duds.

A large part of me believes Baltimore should've done a little more to get a healthy Bateman involved last year. There were games where he failed to reach a 50% snap rate.

But because of the up and down nature of his season — whether it was the injury or the lack of production in spots — we're looking at a wideout who doesn't have the same safe baseline he once had now that he's in the 94th percentile of the Year 2 Model.

Historically, players in the 90th to 95th percentile tier don't totally flop — just 2 of 19 have failed to give fantasy managers a double-digit PPR points per game season in Year 2 or Year 3 — but the ceiling isn't nearly as attractive as it is for a player in the tier one spot above.

Amon-Ra St. Brown

WR • Detroit Lions

73.8%	91.4%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**12.1**
Journey Comparables:	**TY Hilton** **Stefon Diggs** **Keke Coutee**

Among hundreds of wide receivers since 2011 who've entered the league with at least a 50th percentile prospect rating, only two made as big of a leap as Amon-Ra St. Brown did when looking at Z-Prospect percentile to Year 2 percentile. The first is Martavis Bryant, who dominated but had off-the-field issues. The second is Terry McLaurin, who's currently dominating.

St. Brown had a Draft Capital Delta of 3.4%, so the model thought he was underdrafted last season.

It certainly didn't predict this.

After a slow start, St. Brown took off, averaging 25.2 PPR points per game across his final six games of the 2021 season.

That's not a typo.

The Lions had suffered some injuries to key pass-catchers like D'Andre Swift and TJ Hockenson, but 25 points per game doesn't just happen. Something's allowing that to happen. And that "something" is typically talent.

It's tough to find super strong Journey Comparables for St. Brown since his path to relevancy was so bizarre, but his top-two comps are encouraging. TY Hilton entered the league with a prospect score slightly above St. Brown's, and he hit a 90th percentile Year 2 tally. Similarly, Stefon Diggs had a 77th percentile score in the Z-Prospect Model (with a 14% Draft Capital Delta, I should add), and after a decent first year, that jumped to the 89th percentile in the Year 2 Model.

If you have St. Brown on your dynasty roster, your first instinct may be to trade him away. If you feel strongly about it, I won't stop you. I just don't think he's in a bad spot, and his Year 2 score generally agrees.

Kadarius Toney

WR • New York Giants

91.3%	90.8%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**11.9**
Journey Comparables:	**Alshon Jeffery** **Marqise Lee** **Henry Ruggs**

Kadarius Toney was undoubtedly the most controversial wide receiver in last year's class. At least among fantasy football managers.

His statistical profile was nothing to write home about. He had no early-declare status to go along with a best-season yards per team attempt rate that was well below average.

But he hadn't played a ton of wide receiver when he was drafted, so what did we really expect on the production front? And no one could question his athleticism. The man was and is electric with the ball in his hands.

We saw that on full display against the Cowboys in 2021. Toney — who ended up going in the first round of the draft, boosting his Z-Prospect score — caught 10 of 13 targets for 189 yards against Dallas in Week 5.

Unfortunately, not a whole lot happened after that. He was plagued by injury throughout his rookie season, and he wasn't super productive on a per game basis in fantasy.

So Toney was a high-variance prospect who essentially gave us a high-variance Year 1. That's probably why his Journey Comparables seem so confused. He's nothing like Alshon Jeffery as a player, but Jeffery also had an iffy first year thanks to his health, and he bounced back big time in his second season with over 1,400 yards.

But then there's Marqise Lee, a second-round wideout who just could never get things going in the NFL.

Toney's approximate 91st percentile Year 2 score places him in a bucket where buying before the 2022 season is logical. I'd only buy if I'm snagging him from someone who just wasn't a believer in the first place, though. There's no reason to pay a premium right now.

Rondale Moore

WR • Arizona Cardinals

90.2%	89.2%
Z-Prospect Score	Year-2 Model Score
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**11.4**
Journey Comparables:	**Tyler Boyd** **Robert Woods** **Dorial Green-Beckham**

It's tough to find a better age-adjusted college production profile than Rondale Moore's. He was a monster as a Freshman at Purdue, tallying 114 catches for 1,258 yards back in 2018. He just couldn't stay healthy during his next and final two seasons in college, inviting a little more variation to his prospect profile.

The Z-Prospect Model — as you know from reading about it earlier — doesn't care *that* much about size. Sometimes that's a good thing (Calvin Ridley, Marquise Brown), but sometimes it's not. Sometimes it likes, oh, I don't know, Tutu Atwell a little more than it should. (More on that in a second.)

Let's just face the facts: Rondale Moore is small. He's 5'7''. As I noted in the prospect profiles section earlier, the best hit since 2011 at wide receiver among wideouts who have been 5'8'' or shorter — so an inch taller than Moore — has probably been Jamison Crowder.

You can easily argue that Moore is an outlier among these shorter dudes due to his college production, but, straight up, it's just tough for me, personally, to want to push my chips to the center of the table for a receiver who's that short. Had he crushed his rookie year, maybe I'd feel differently.

But he didn't.

Moore's Journey Comparables aren't all that bad, with Tyler Boyd and Robert Woods popping up as top comparisons. Those players may have had similar Z-Prospect and Year 2 scores as Moore, but they're not Rondale Moore. They don't have the same size concerns.

As fun as Moore is as a player, and as much as I'd love to call him a buy, he's more of a hold at his Year 2 Model score.

Nico Collins

WR • Houston Texans

74.1%	76.9%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**7.6**
Journey Comparables:	**Tajae Sharpe** **Michael Gallup** **Tre'Quan Smith**

Once you get past Rondale Moore within the 2021 wide receiver class, there's a Grand Canyon-sized gap to the next player, Nico Collins.

Collins entered the NFL with good size and a strong Breakout Age, but across the three main production metrics in the Z-Prospect Model, he was pretty below average. His draft capital helped get him to a 74th percentile prospect score, but at wide receiver, that's nothing special. Since 2011, no wide receiver under the 80th percentile has scored 16 or more PPR points in B2S. In the 80th to 85th percentile range, that rate rises to 14%.

On a team with a pretty wide open depth chart, Collins wasn't terrible as a rookie. He averaged a target share per game of 13.2%, and he had a few 50-yard performances. Really, that's fine for a player with his profile.

The reason his rank rose from Year 1 to Year 2 is because most players in his shoes don't do much at all during their first season in the league. Collins at least gave you something.

His Journey Comparables aren't thrilling, but Michael Gallup could be worse. If you want to hang onto that, feel free. Just know that Collins' chances of becoming anything more than a WR2 are minuscule.

Terrace Marshall

WR • Carolina Panthers

86.3%	75.9%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**7.4**
Journey Comparables:	**Devin Smith** **James Washington** **Bryan Edwards**

The biggest mistake I made as a draft analyst in 2021 was with Terrace Marshall.

As you can see, Marshall had an 86th percentile mark in the Z-Prospect Model. Being under the 95th percentile meant that his chances of being truly special weren't high. He had a shot to be quite good, but historically good? Not happening with that score.

In my post-draft rankings, I placed Marshall fourth overall, ahead of Elijah Moore and Rashod Bateman, who, as you've already seen, were actually in that 95th to 100th percentile tier.

Why? Why did I make this obvious mistake?

Well, this is where adding subjectivity can come back to bite you. To me, it was all about upside. Marshall has typical alpha wide receiver size, and during his Sophomore season at LSU, he was competing well with Ja'Marr Chase and Justin Jefferson before getting hurt. Fast forward to the pandemic season, and he dominated during the chunk of games that he was active for.

So, similar to Jaylen Waddle, Marshall had an unfinished production profile. And given the success of Justin Jefferson and the projected success of Ja'Marr Chase, it seemed reasonable to say, "Terrace Marshall's got a whole lot of potential!"

The mistake didn't stem from that logic, in my opinion. The mistake was valuing Marshall's upside more than Elijah Moore's or Rashod Bateman's. The mistake was ignoring what the model was saying.

My re-commitment to the Z-Prospect Model in 2022 stems from this error. It was a slip in process, and I paid. Because, today, Marshall is not in a good spot. After a disappointing rookie year, his Journey Comparables are filled with underachievers. He's gone from someone I was touting to someone I'm likely selling in just one season.

D’Wayne Eskridge

WR • Seattle Seahawks

84.7%	75.1%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**7.1**
Journey Comparables:	**Andy Isabella** **Bryan Edwards** **DJ Chark**

The Z-Prospect Model didn’t mind D’Wayne Eskridge because he had an absurdly high best-season receiving yards per team attempt rate of 4.92. The only player in my database with a higher mark in the statistic was Jalen Robinette, who played in the run-heavy Air Force offense. The Seahawks then went out and snagged Eskridge in Round 2, giving him good draft capital.

Despite the high yards per team pass attempt mark, Eskridge had a negative Draft Capital Delta. He was overdrafted. And he was overdrafted because of all the age-related items the model looks at.

Eskridge entered the league at 24 years old after playing five years at Western Michigan. I mean, just re-read that sentence. There are a lot of issues there. He wasn’t an early-declare receiver. He was old. And he went to a smaller school.

Not great, Bob!

After a rookie campaign that saw him catch 10 passes for 64 yards, it’s hard to imagine a scenario where Eskridge becomes an every-week starter for your dynasty lineup.

Josh Palmer

WR • Los Angeles Chargers

67.8%	73.9%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**6.7**
Journey Comparables:	**TJ Graham** **Marvin Jones** **Trent Taylor**

We've seen Josh Palmer rise up dynasty rankings over the last month or two, though that's likely to stop with Mike Williams re-signing with the Chargers.

Palmer got more run at the end of the 2021 season, averaging a target share per game of almost 15% across his final five games. He gave us a pair of top-24 performances during that stretch, too.

It's an obvious point to make, but a huge piece to the allure with Palmer is his situation. He's tied to one of the best young passers in football in Justin Herbert.

A wide receiver still needs to be reliable in order to produce, even with a stud quarterback. And that's where the model questions things. Entering the league, Palmer had a low 68th percentile Z-Prospect score, giving him a minimal chance to become an important piece to the fantasy football world.

His score was so mediocre because his college production was mediocre. Actually, it was worse than mediocre. Palmer had poor statistics in the three main Z-Prospect production categories, finishing college with a best-season yards per team attempt rate of 1.67. He wasn't an early declare, and his Breakout Age was nothing special.

From 2011 through 2019, there hasn't been a single wide receiver from the Z-Prospect Model that entered the league with a sub-75th percentile score to give us one season of 16 or more PPR points per game across his first three years in the league. That's a mouthful, but it's important. It shows us that even if you trade Palmer away, chances are, you're not trading away a stud.

Dyami Brown

WR • Washington Commanders

83.4%	71.5%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**6.2**
Journey Comparables:	**Cody Latimer** **DeVier Posey** **Leonte Carroo**

The Z-Prospect Model didn't mind Dyami Brown last offseason. He was a big-play receiver in college, and those huge receptions helped bring up his best-season yards per team pass attempt rate above the 3.0 mark, which is a solid threshold to hit.

Injuries hurt Brown's Year 1 potential, but we can't blame it all on that since he played 15 games. He was active for four contests with significant snaps, failing to rank higher than WR61 in weekly scoring in any of them.

Unfortunately, it looks like a miss for the model. It's not like he was above the 90th percentile or anything, but wideouts over the 80th percentile mark usually have some shot. With Brown, it doesn't look like it's going to happen.

Tutu Atwell

WR • Los Angeles Rams

86.9%	71.1%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**6.1**
Journey Comparables:	**Breshad Perriman** **Cody Latimer** **Andy Isabella**

You're eyes are not deceiving you: Tutu Atwell had a Z-Prospect score in the 87th percentile. This, my friends, is the quintessential example of why we shouldn't just blindly follow this thing.

Could I put something in the model to say, "Stop! Hold it right there! You're looking at a 155-pound wide receiver! You don't want to draft him!"

Yes, sure. But I just do it instinctively instead.

I mentioned earlier that wide receiver size isn't a huge part of the model. It's probably because it's working across a large sample. And, also, size is likely captured in draft capital.

Unfortunately, there will be oddities that the model doesn't catch. Rather than change up a formula that has strong results, it's easier to just recognize a player as a clear anomaly and move on. And that's what I did with Atwell.

Truth be told, Atwell had very impressive college numbers. And then the Rams screwed everything up by taking him in the second round of the draft. So the Z-Prospect Model sees the production, it only knocks him a tad for the size, it sees the draft capital, and it says "Hey, he's not that bad!"

Fortunately, my rankings didn't have Atwell ranked high at all. It was hard – and still is – to fathom a 155-pound wide receiver thriving in fantasy football at the NFL level.

Perhaps my personal opinion here will end up being completely wrong. With Journey Comparables like Cody Latimer and Andy Isabella, I'll bet that I'm not.

Anthony Schwartz

WR • Cleveland Browns

76.3%	69.1%
Z-Prospect Score	**Year-2 Model Score**
Expected Max PPR PPG Season:	**5.5**
Journey Comparables:	**Pharoh Cooper** **Van Jefferson** **Stedman Bailey**

Are we sure the Rams didn't draft Anthony Schwartz? With Journey Comparables of Pharoh Cooper (drafted by the Rams in 2016), Van Jefferson (drafted by the Rams in 2020), and Stedman Bailey (drafted by the Rams in 2013), it seems like he should've been.

Schwartz had an opportunity to take on a relatively large role in the Cleveland offense this past year with such a shallow wide receiver depth chart, but nothing happened. He saw five targets in Week 1 against the Chiefs, and that ended up being his season high. He totaled just 18 more targets from then through the end of the season.

He's incredibly fast and can likely serve a field-stretching role in the league, but with a 69th percentile Year 2 Model ranking, his odds of becoming a dependable fantasy football piece are almost non-existent. Among the 37 wide receivers with Year 2 Model scores in the 60th to 70th percentile from 2011 to 2019, only one gave you a single season during Year 2 or Year 3 with 10 or more PPR points per game. And it was the undrafted Jakobi Meyers, who had to climb the proverbial ladder to get there.

Closing

We've now done two of the three things we set out to do at the start of this guide.

We got deep into this stuff. You now know the many inputs that go into these models. More importantly, you now understand the *why*. *Why* does early-declare status matter for wide receivers? *Why* is draft capital important? *Why* does the running back model have more variance than the wide receiver one? *Why* was JJ a complete moron with his approach to Terrace Marshall last year?

We got nerdy. You know how I know we got nerdy? Because you're currently reading Page 138 of an analytical guide about prospects in fantasy football.

We've got one more thing to do now.

Let's go win.